

Agnes Grey



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ANNE BRONTË

Anne Brontë was born in northern England in 1820, the youngest daughter of Irish-born clergyman Patrick Brontë and his wife Maria Brontë née Branwell. She had five older siblings: Maria, Elizabeth, Charlotte, Patrick Branwell, and Emily. In 1821, Brontë's mother Maria died, and her aunt Elizabeth Branwell moved in with the family to raise the children. In 1825, Brontë's oldest sisters Maria and Elizabeth died of tuberculosis. Brontë was largely homeschooled, though as a teenager she attended Roe Head, a girls' school where her older sister Charlotte had been a pupil and subsequently a teacher. In 1839, at age 19, she worked as a governess for the Ingham family, whose poorly behaved children she was not allowed to discipline. The Inghams nevertheless blamed Brontë for their children's failure to improve and fired her. In 1840, Brontë began working as a governess for the Robinson family at Thorpe Green Hall; they employed her until 1846, when she gave notice. Also in 1846, Brontë and her sisters Charlotte and Emily published a jointly authored poetry collection under male pseudonyms, *Poems by Currer, Ellis, and Acton Bell*. Though almost no one bought the collection, Brontë later published her poetry in various literary magazines under the same pseudonym, Acton Bell. In 1847, Brontë's first novel *Agnes Grey*, a semi-autobiographical representation of Brontë's career as a governess, was published. In 1848, Brontë published her second novel, *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall*. Also in 1848, Brontë's brother Patrick Branwell and her sister Emily died, likely of tuberculosis. Brontë died of tuberculosis the next year, 1849, at age 29.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Agnes Grey takes place in rural, northern England during the first half of the 1800s. In the early 1800s, most English schools were religiously affiliated and many poor English children had no access to education at all. In 1833, the UK's Parliament voted to begin national funding of schools for poor children. Yet upper-middle and upper-class parents tended to send their older sons to private schools and to arrange private, live-in female tutors for their younger children and daughters. These private, live-in female tutors were called governesses. Governesses occupied a peculiar space in Victorian culture because they tended to be unmarried, educated women who worked to support themselves, which was unusual for middle-class women at the time. As such, they came from the same social class—or at least a similar social class—to the families that employed them, but they were not considered that family's

social equals. This dynamic is evident throughout *Agnes Grey*. The families that employ Agnes as a governess expect her to model appropriate behavior, manners, morals, and knowledge to their children, expectations betraying that they recognize Agnes as coming from a similar social class to theirs. And yet these same families treat Agnes as a social inferior, forbidding her from disciplining their children and failing to acknowledge her in social situations.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

In Anne Brontë's first novel *Agnes Grey*, Agnes's flirtatious teenaged pupil Rosalie Murray marries Sir Thomas Ashby, an aristocrat with a bad reputation, for his title and money. Rosalie ends up miserable, learning after the wedding that Sir Ashby is frequently drunk and prone to infidelity. Anne Brontë's second novel, *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall* (1848), similarly represents a young woman's unhappy marriage to an unfaithful, alcoholic aristocrat, Arthur Huntington. These representations may have influenced George Eliot's late novel *Daniel Deronda* (1876), in which flirtatious young Gwendolen Harleth makes a disastrous marriage to yet another dissipated aristocrat, Henleigh Mallinger Grandcourt. *Agnes Grey* also represents its titular protagonist making her living first as a governess and then as a teacher. Its representations of Victorian women working in education may have influenced the novels of Anne's sister Charlotte Brontë, whose novel *Jane Eyre* (1847), published the same year as *Agnes Grey*, likewise has a governess protagonist and whose later novel *Villette* (1853) represents the struggles of young, orphaned Lucy Snow to make her living as an English teacher in France.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Agnes Grey*
- **When Written:** Early 1840s
- **Where Written:** England
- **When Published:** 1847
- **Literary Period:** Victorian
- **Genre:** Realism, Romance Novel
- **Setting:** Victorian England
- **Climax:** Mr. Weston proposes to Agnes.
- **Antagonist:** Tom Bloomfield, Uncle Robson, Rosalie Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Mr. Weston/Mr. Weightman: Literary historians speculate that

the romantic hero of *Agnes Grey*, the curate Mr. Weston, may have been based on a handsome young curate at Anne Brontë's home parish of Hathorne, William Weightman, who died in his mid-twenties.

Wuthering Heights: *Agnes Grey* may have received less critical attention than the work of Anne Brontë's sisters in part because *Agnes Grey* was published as the third volume in a three-volume set, where the first two volumes comprised Emily Brontë's [Wuthering Heights](#), a more controversial and overtly dramatic novel.



PLOT SUMMARY

Richard Grey is a poor clergyman in northern England. He marries his wife, Alice, against the wishes of her rich family, so Alice's family disowns her. They have six children, but only two—Mary and Agnes—survive past childhood. Richard, anxious that his wife's standard of living has declined since marrying him, tries to make money by investing in a merchant ship, but when the ship sinks, the Greys are poorer than before. Richard is devastated, and his health suffers. Agnes, now 18, resolves to become a governess to help the family finances.

Agnes gets a job as a governess with the Bloomfield family, acquaintances of her aunt. At the Bloomfield house, Agnes becomes responsible for 7-year-old Tom Bloomfield and his younger sisters Mary Ann and Fanny. She quickly learns that Tom, with the encouragement of his father Mr. Bloomfield and his Uncle Robson, likes to torture helpless [animals](#). She tries to teach him that cruelty to animals is wicked, but he refuses to listen. Although the Bloomfield children are lazy and disobedient, Mrs. Bloomfield gives Agnes no authority to punish them and undermines her attempts to discipline them. Eventually, she fires Agnes, blaming her for the children's failure to improve.

Determined not to give up, Agnes gets another governess job with the Murray family, who live 70 miles away. She is primarily responsible for the Murrays' two teenage daughters, vain and pretty Rosalie and tomboy Matilda. Their mother Mrs. Murray wants her daughters to gain educational accomplishments that will make them attractive to rich, well-born suitors, but—like Mrs. Bloomfield—she doesn't want Agnes disciplining her children or forcing them to work hard.

On Rosalie's 18th birthday, the Murrays host a huge ball. Agnes isn't present during the festivities—she goes home to celebrate Christmas with her family and attend her sister Mary's wedding. But when she returns, Rosalie gloats about all the men who admired her at the ball, including rich aristocrat Sir Thomas Ashby, charming younger son Harry Meltham, and the village rector Mr. Hatfield. Rosalie also mentions that Mr. Hatfield has a new curate, Mr. Weston, whom she criticizes as

ugly and charmless. When Agnes asks Rosalie which of her suitors she likes best, she says that she doesn't like any of them—but she'll probably end up marrying Sir Ashby, despite rumors of his immorality.

When Agnes hears the new curate Mr. Weston preach in church, she thinks that he is intelligent and sincerely religious, unlike the status-obsessed Mr. Hatfield. One day, Agnes is visiting a poor cottager in the village, Nancy Brown, who has been suffering from an eye inflammation and likes Agnes to read to her. Nancy suffers from "melancholy." During Agnes's visit, Nancy mentions that when she sought help and comfort from Mr. Hatfield, he criticized her—but when Mr. Weston heard about her problems, he visited her and gave her excellent, comforting advice. Agnes is happy that Mr. Weston gives her an opportunity to contemplate human goodness. Eventually, she is personally introduced to him when they visit Nancy at the same time.

One spring day, Agnes is walking back to the Murrays' house from church when she sees some [primroses](#) blooming high up in a tree's roots. She tries to reach them but can't. Mr. Weston walks up behind her and plucks them for her. They discuss Agnes's favorite flowers and whether they gain more comfort from having a home or having meaningful work. Later, Rosalie and Matilda tease Agnes about her conversation with Mr. Weston. Agnes claims that they have nothing to tease her for—but she presses one of the primroses into her Bible.

The next day, after lessons, Agnes is completing a watercolor at Rosalie's request when Mrs. Murray bustles in and asks where Rosalie is. When Agnes says that Rosalie has gone for a walk, Mrs. Murray explains that when Rosalie walks off the Murray property, Mr. Hatfield has been finding her. She asks Agnes to go find Rosalie and remind her not to speak with admirers unchaperoned. Agnes finds Rosalie talking flirtatiously with Mr. Hatfield in a field just outside the Murray property. After he leaves, Agnes informs Rosalie that Mrs. Murray doesn't want her walking off the Murray property unchaperoned—and Rosalie, annoyed, says that she's in no danger of falling in love, let alone with Mr. Hatfield, who isn't rich enough. She also expresses annoyance that her mother doesn't want her flirting with anyone except Sir Ashby, in case Sir Ashby's mother hears negative gossip about Rosalie—though the gossip about Sir Ashby's behavior is far worse.

Four days later, Agnes is chaperoning Rosalie on a walk when Rosalie abruptly sends Agnes on an errand to give money to a poor, dying villager. As Agnes is returning from the errand, Rosalie rushes up to Agnes and explains that Mr. Hatfield just found her and proposed to her—and that she heroically rejected him. Afterward, he threatened to spread damaging gossip about her flirtatious behavior if she told anyone he'd proposed, so she promised not to. Agnes points out to Rosalie that she's already broken her promise and counsels her not to tell anyone else except her mother.

Rosalie is bored now that her flirtation with Mr. Hatfield has ended. One day, she insists Agnes accompany her on a walk into town. Mr. Weston sees Agnes and engages her in conversation. Rosalie talks vivaciously to Mr. Weston and, when Mr. Weston leaves, gloats to Agnes that she has captivated him. Agnes, horrified, hopes that Rosalie is incorrect—for Mr. Weston's sake and her own. Later, Rosalie tells Agnes that as Sir Ashby will likely propose soon, she wants to conquer Mr. Weston's heart before then. The following week, Rosalie accepts a marriage proposal from Sir Ashby at a ball. As the engagement is kept quiet, Rosalie continues attempting to "conquer" various men.

In the summer, after Rosalie marries Sir Ashby and goes on her honeymoon, Agnes and Matilda run into Mr. Weston while they are all visiting poor villagers. Mr. Weston asks after Rosalie, but Agnes notes that he seems in no way sad about Rosalie's marriage—except insofar as he has heard alarming gossip about Sir Ashby. The next day, Agnes receives a letter from her family saying that her father is extremely sick. Agnes rushes home, but her father has already died. After the funeral, Agnes decides to quit her job with the Murrays and open a small school with her mother. She returns to the Murrays and gives notice. During her last week in the village, Mr. Weston approaches her after church, says goodbye to her, and asks whether it would matter to her whether they met again. She says she would like that a great deal.

Agnes and her mother open a small school in a coastal town. For a while, Agnes hopes to hear from Mr. Weston—but when she doesn't, she resolves to stop pining for him. The next June, she receives a letter from Rosalie asking her to visit Ashby Park. When Agnes visits, she discovers that Rosalie is miserable: her husband is unfaithful, jealous, and frequently drunk. Agnes tries to give Rosalie helpful advice, but she suspects that Rosalie won't follow it.

Shortly after returning from Ashby Park, Agnes goes for an early walk on the beach when, unexpectedly, she runs into Mr. Weston. He walks her home. He mentions that he wasn't able to figure out where she had moved and asks whether he could call on her mother. Agnes agrees. Mr. Weston and Agnes's mother get on excellently, and Mr. Weston begins calling regularly, becoming a close family friend. Then, one evening, he proposes to Agnes, revealing that he has received her mother's consent. Mr. Weston and Agnes get married, have three children, and live happily together.

a large sum on a mercantile investment and becomes ill, she resolves to help support the family by working as a governess. As a governess, Agnes learns the hard way that the wealthy families who hire her do not want her to discipline their children in any way—but will still blame her for their children's bad behavior. Nevertheless, Agnes—a lover of **animals**—tries to teach her pupils to be kind, morally upstanding, and compassionate. This generally goes poorly for Agnes: for instance, when she tries to teach her first pupil, seven-year-old Tom Bloomfield, not to torture helpless baby birds, Tom's mother Mrs. Bloomfield criticizes Agnes for hindering Tom's enjoyments and eventually fires Agnes. In her second job, Agnes becomes depressed by the status- and wealth-consciousness of her employer Mrs. Murray and her oldest pupil Rosalie Murray. She falls in love with the new village curate, Mr. Weston, in large part because his religious sincerity and charitable works give her a person in her immediate environs that she can admire. After Agnes's father dies, Agnes gives notice at the Murrays and founds a small school with her widowed mother. Though she prefers working as a schoolteacher to working as a governess, Agnes happily leaves the school to marry Mr. Weston when he proposes to her. Agnes and Mr. Weston live joyfully together, having three children and living simply.

Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey – Alice is the daughter of a rich squire who disinherited her when she chose to marry the poor clergyman she loved, Richard Grey, rather than some wealthy and titled man. A brave, principled, and resilient woman, Alice never regrets having given up wealth and status for love. She homeschools her two surviving children, Mary and Agnes, and does her best to keep the family within its meager budget. Though initially hesitant about Agnes's plan to work as a governess, Alice later helps her daughter find work. After Richard dies following a long illness, Alice receives a letter from her father offering to support her financially and write Mary and Agnes into his will if Alice will only apologize for and admit she regrets marrying Richard. Alice refuses on principle, saying she has no regrets. Afterwards, she and Agnes found a small but growing school together in a fashionable coastal town in England. She gets along very well with Agnes's suitor Mr. Weston and gives her consent when he asks to propose to Agnes.

Agnes's Father/Richard Grey – A poor clergyman in northern England, Richard Grey marries Agnes's mother Alice against the wishes of Alice's rich family. He loves and respects Alice more than he wants financial support from a prospective wife's family. Nevertheless, the melancholy and anxious Richard feels guilty that he cannot support Alice in the fine style in which she was raised. The pair have six children, but only two, Mary and Agnes, survive to adulthood. When Alice is about 18, Richard tries to improve the family's fortunes by investing in a mercantile venture—but when the merchant's ship sinks, the



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Agnes Grey – Agnes Grey, the younger daughter of poor clergyman Richard Grey and his wife Alice Grey, is a sheltered and naïve but determined young woman. When her father loses

Greys are impoverished. The shock of this loss permanently damages Richard's health. He dies a few years later after a lingering illness.

Mary – Mary is older sister to Agnes and the oldest surviving child of Alice and Richard Grey. While Agnes is working as a governess, Mary—then aged 28—marries the 30-something vicar of a nearby parish, a man who is neither handsome nor rich but whose goodness she admires. After Richard Grey dies, Mary asks her mother Alice to come live with her and her husband, but Alice chooses to start a small school with Agnes rather than become a drain on Mary's household.

Mr. Weston – Mr. Weston is the new curate in the village nearest the Murrays' country home, Horton Lodge. Less than a year before he took the position, his beloved mother died; he deals with his grief by throwing himself into his work and trying to better the lives of the poor villagers around him. Due to his religious sincerity, charitable works, and intellectual straightforwardness, Agnes clings to him as an image of human goodness while she is surrounded by status-seeking superficiality at the Murrays. Agnes quickly falls in love with him. Though Rosalie Murray attempts to make a "conquest" of Mr. Weston, Mr. Weston seems immune to her charms and bemused by her attention. A year after Agnes leaves her job with the Murrays, she and Mr. Weston run into one another by chance on the beach, and Mr. Weston reveals that—unable to work with the status-obsessed rector in the Murrays' village, Mr. Hatfield—he has taken a curacy in a village near the school. He begins to call regularly on Agnes and her mother; eventually, he confesses his love to Agnes and asks her to marry him. They have three children and live simply and happily together.

Rosalie Murray – The oldest daughter of Mr. Murray and Mrs. Murray, Rosalie is Agnes's full-time pupil from age 16 to age 18, after which Agnes continues to give her lessons only in German and drawing. Though intelligent and talented at music and foreign languages, Rosalie has received a poor moral education from her superficial, status-obsessed parents. As a result, she is only interested in learning subjects that will make her more attractive to admirers and finds her chief pleasure in "conquering" men's hearts—though she is not interested in falling in love herself. She causes Agnes a great deal of anxiety and pain when, in a fit of boredom, she tries to make the secret object of Agnes's affections, village curate Mr. Weston, fall in love with her. At her mother's urging, Rosalie marries the rich aristocrat Sir Thomas Ashby, because he is the richest and highest-ranking man likely to propose to her. Only after the marriage does Rosalie discover his drunkenness, gambling, infidelity, and jealousy. Isolated and miserable at her new country estate Ashby Park, Rosalie invites Agnes to visit her and her baby daughter—but when Agnes counsels Rosalie to try to reform her husband and devote herself to their child, Rosalie expresses scorn for both projects, wishing that she

could still flirt and seek pleasure without obstacles. Agnes predicts that Rosalie's life will be permanently unhappy due not only to her unwise marriage but also to her distorted value system.

Matilda Murray – Matilda, younger sister to Rosalie Murray, is one of Agnes's students in her second governess position. Fourteen years old when Agnes arrives in the Murray household, Matilda is a thorough tomboy, who loves riding, hunting, and repeating the curse words that she has learned from her father Mr. Murray and his grooms. Although Matilda's unladylike behavior predates Agnes's employment with the Murrays, Matilda's mother Mrs. Murray nevertheless blames Agnes for not using flattery to make Matilda behave in a more feminine manner.

Mrs. Murray – Wife to Mr. Murray and mother to Rosalie and Matilda, Mrs. Murray is an attractive, fashionable forty-something whose primary focus is marrying her daughters to the richest, highest-ranking men possible. As such, she judges the family governess Agnes primarily on her ability to bestow attractive accomplishments on her daughters. To Agnes's disapproval and dismay, Mrs. Murray encourages Rosalie's disastrous marriage to the immoral aristocrat Sir Thomas Ashby—despite having heard rumors about his objectionable behavior. After Rosalie marries, Mrs. Murray focuses her energy on turning her tomboy younger daughter Matilda into an attractive marriage prospect.

Mr. Murray – Husband to Mrs. Murray and father to Rosalie and Matilda, Mr. Murray is a wealthy country squire who devotes himself to hunting, riding, and farming. He rarely troubles himself with his children's governess, Agnes, who almost never sees him except when the family attends church—though she occasionally hears him cursing at his male employees.

Sir Thomas Ashby – Admirer and eventual husband of Rosalie Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby is an immoral aristocrat devoted to drinking, gambling, and conducting romantic affairs. Mrs. Murray, pleased by Sir Thomas Ashby's money and social status, encourages Rosalie to marry him despite having heard rumors of his bad reputation. Rosalie's governess Agnes counsels against the marriage, but no one listens to her. After the wedding, Sir Thomas Ashby and Rosalie have a baby—and Sir Thomas is angry at Rosalie because the baby is a daughter. He drinks heavily, is unfaithful to Rosalie, and is jealous of Rosalie's admirer Harry Meltham. He and Rosalie are living together unhappily in the countryside when, after their honeymoon, Agnes pays a short visit to Rosalie.

Mr. Hatfield – The village rector at the church the Murray family attends, Mr. Hatfield is a vain, status-obsessed man who flatters his rich parishioners and threatens the poor ones with hell. He falls in love with and pursues the flirtatious Rosalie Murray. When she refuses his proposal of marriage, he threatens to spread damaging rumors about her flirtatious

behavior unless she promises not to tell anyone that he proposed. Eventually he marries a rich older woman. His inability to get along with his new curate Mr. Weston, a less status-conscious and more sincerely religious man, eventually leads Mr. Weston to take another curacy on the coast near the small school founded by Agnes Grey and her mother Alice.

Nancy Brown – Nancy Brown is a poor, elderly, devoutly religious cottager in the village near the Murrays' estate, Horton Lodge. When she develops an eye inflammation that prevents her from reading the Bible, Agnes begins visiting her to read to her. From Nancy, Agnes learns that the village rector Mr. Hatfield treated Nancy's "melancholy" (depression) quite dismissively when she asked for his help and counsel—but that the new curate Mr. Weston sought her out, gave her good advice, and helped her considerably. Mr. Weston's kind treatment of Nancy Brown contributes to Agnes's falling in love with him.

Tom Bloomfield – Tom Bloomfield is a blond, blue-eyed seven-year-old who becomes Agnes's oldest pupil when she first goes to work as a governess. Tom is spoiled by his doting mother Mrs. Bloomfield and encouraged to drink alcohol and torture **animals** by his father Mr. Bloomfield and his Uncle Robson. Though Agnes tries to teach Tom moral virtues and dissuade him from animal cruelty, she lacks the authority to mitigate his older relatives' poor example and is eventually fired for his and his sisters' unruly behavior.

Mrs. Bloomfield – Mrs. Bloomfield is an acquaintance of Agnes Grey's aunt and the first person to employ Agnes as a governess for her school-aged children Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny. Cold and haughty, Mrs. Bloomfield will not allow an employee like Agnes to discipline her children yet blames Agnes for their poor behavior. She eventually fires Agnes because her children are so poorly behaved.

Uncle Robson – Brother to Mrs. Bloomfield and uncle to Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny, Uncle Robson is a tall, strong, unintelligent man who encourages Tom to drink alcohol and torture helpless **animals** and praises Mary Ann's prettiness while ignoring her intelligence and good behavior. Agnes sees him as a bad influence on the Bloomfield children, undoing any progress she manages to make with them.

Mary Ann Bloomfield – Younger sister to Tom Bloomfield, Mary Ann is a large, rosy-cheeked six-year-old. Spoiled, vain, and lazy, Mary Ann often refuses to do the work her governess Agnes assigns to her and screams at painful volume when Agnes attempts—against Mary Ann's parents' wishes—to discipline her. Mary Ann's mother Mrs. Bloomfield eventually fires Agnes for her children's poor behavior.

Mr. Bloomfield – Husband to Mrs. Bloomfield and father to Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny, Mr. Bloomfield is an angry, complaining man whose outbursts of temper frighten his children into acting well-behaved around him. As a result, he

blames and criticizes the family's governess Agnes for her inability to control the children, failing to account for the fact that Agnes has been forbidden from disciplining them.

Henry "Harry" Meltham – The younger son of aristocrat Sir Hugh Meltham, Harry Meltham is one of Rosalie Murray's admirers. Though Rosalie is not interested in marrying a younger son, Harry Meltham continues to pursue Rosalie in London after her marriage to Sir Thomas Ashby, leading a jealous Sir Thomas Ashby to withdraw with Rosalie to the Ashby country estate.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Fanny Bloomfield – The youngest of Agnes's pupils at the Bloomfields' house, Fanny is a pretty four-year-old whom her mother Mrs. Bloomfield believes to be "gentle" but whom Agnes quickly learns is a terror.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



EDUCATION, AUTHORITY, AND CLASS

Agnes Grey suggests that children learn their behavior and values first and foremost from their parents and families. Rich parents try to offload the responsibility of educating their children in values as well as academic subjects onto governesses, women of their genteel social class but a lower economic class. Yet because the parents treat governesses like servants, not equals, the governesses lack the authority to enforce their teachings. Thus, rich children learn to treat the governesses with contempt and therefore never really learn from them. This complicated dynamic plays out in both governess jobs held by the novel's titular protagonist, Agnes. In her first job, with the Bloomfield family, young Tom Bloomfield has already learned to ignore women in authority and to torture **animals** from his father Mr. Bloomfield and his Uncle Robson. Agnes tries to model better behavior for Tom, yet because his parents—who don't want a poor woman disciplining their son—won't give her the authority to punish him for bad behavior, she has no leverage to shape Tom, and so he never improves. In Agnes's second job, with the Murray family, she tries to teach moral seriousness and dutifulness to teenage flirt Rosalie Murray and ladylike behavior to swearing tomboy Matilda. Yet once again, Agnes's employer Mrs. Murray tells Agnes to leave any serious criticism of her children to her because she believes a governess doing so would be socially inappropriate. At the same time as she deprives Agnes of

authority, Mrs. Murray encourages irresponsibly flirtatious Rosalie to catch the richest man she can and largely avoids responsibility for Matilda's behavior. She then blames Agnes rather than herself or Mr. Murray for habits her children developed before Agnes was hired. Unsurprisingly, Agnes makes no headway with Rosalie or Matilda—and Rosalie ends up in a disastrous marriage with a rich but cruel aristocrat, Sir Ashby, against Agnes's express advice. Thus, the novel illustrates how rich parents, due to their classism, undermine governesses' authority and so prevent them from effectively teaching children good values.



MONEY VS. LOVE IN MARRIAGE

In *Agnes Grey*, genteel women are pressured to marry for money and rank and punished socially if they don't—yet the novel suggests that women who marry for love have at least a chance at happiness, while those who marry for money end up miserable. The novel illustrates the pressure women face to marry for money and rank through both Agnes's mother and Agnes's student Rosalie Murray. Agnes's mother, the daughter of a rich squire, fell in love with Agnes's father Richard Grey, who's a poor clergyman but a good person. When she chose to marry him rather than a man with money and a title, her rich family disowned her. Yet despite the Greys' limited means, they have a happy marriage. After Richard dies, Agnes's mother receives a letter from her father offering to support her financially and write Agnes and her sister Mary into his will if she will admit she was wrong to marry Richard—highlighting that the pressure to marry for money never fully disappears, even as it changes form over time. Agnes's mother refuses, claiming never to have regretted her 30 years of marriage to her best friend. By contrast, 18-year-old Rosalie Murray marries Sir Thomas Ashby—with her mother Mrs. Murray's express encouragement—despite having heard alarming rumors about his character, because he is the richest and highest-born of her many suitors. She almost immediately regrets the decision, finding Sir Thomas a controlling husband who cheats on her and drinks too much. Agnes's mother's fate suggests that while a good marriage doesn't guarantee total happiness (money problems and death are, the novel shows, still inevitable), women who marry men they love and admire have a chance at good times and the consolation of self-respect in hard times. Rosalie's fate, on the other hand, shows that women who marry men who aren't good people and who they don't love are doomed to be miserable even in rich surroundings.



WOMEN AND FULFILLMENT

In *Agnes Grey*, upper-class women in Victorian society have limited options for exercising their talents or fulfilling their ambitions. But the novel suggests that women with good moral educations can find

happiness despite these limitations, while those without good moral educations often end up behaving destructively due to their limited agency. The limitations on women become immediately clear in *Agnes Grey* when Agnes's father, Richard Grey, loses money on an investment and becomes sick. His poor daughters Agnes and Mary have only a few socially acceptable options to support themselves economically during their father's illness: they can marry, teach in a school, or become governesses—and that's about all. When Agnes goes to work as a governess—a poorly paid, thankless, and lonely job—she survives mainly due to her good moral education. She insists on behaving well according to her own standards and derives her self-respect from doing so, something that keeps her mostly fulfilled.

By contrast, Agnes's pretty teenage student Rosalie Murray has had a poor moral education. Though Rosalie is intelligent enough and is good at music and foreign languages, her mother Mrs. Murray wants her to accomplish and learn only that which will make her attractive to a rich, high-ranking potential husband. Under her mother's malign influence, Rosalie grows up vain, shallow, and wants only to “conquer” men. After she marries rich aristocrat Sir Thomas Ashby, she has achieved the goal of her education. However, she feels bored, thwarted, and miserable, as she lacks the resilience of someone like Agnes. When she tries to exercise her talent for flirtation—the one thing she's really good at—while married, her jealous husband is furious and secludes her in the countryside. Rosalie's misery shows that limited social roles for women tend to privilege the attainment of the wrong skills and create unhappiness.



POWER AND CRUELTY

Agnes Grey illustrates how hierarchies lead to cruelty unless those high in the hierarchy receive careful moral educations—which few of them do.

This pattern appears both in Agnes's employers' treatment of her and various high-ranking characters' treatment of [animals](#). When Agnes is working for the Bloomfields, for instance, her young charge Tom Bloomfield is the spoiled prince of the Bloomfield family, and so he sits at the top of the domestic hierarchy. Because no one except Agnes (who has almost no power or standing due to being a governess) has ever tried to teach him consideration for others, he regularly hits Agnes and his sisters and tortures helpless birds. When Agnes is working for the Murrays, meanwhile, her charges Rosalie and Matilda rarely consider her comfort, often thoughtlessly wound her, and exclude her whenever they socialize with their richer friends. Tellingly, Matilda also fails to show adequate kindness to Snap, the terrier puppy she attempts to raise. After Agnes—who loves animals—accepts responsibility for Snap and raises him herself, the Murrays spitefully sell Snap to a rat-catcher for the supposed crime of preferring Agnes to Matilda. Through high-status characters' cruel or careless treatment of

poor Agnes and helpless animals, the novel repeatedly suggests that whenever a hierarchy of power exists, those at the top will tend to treat those at the bottom badly.



RELIGION

Agnes Grey suggests that all too frequently, people practice religion in an insincere way—but when they practice it sincerely, it can be a great comfort

in adversity. The novel's main example of religious insincerity is Mr. Hatfield, the rector at the village parish in Horton, where Agnes lives with the Murray family. Mr. Hatfield uses his elevated social status as rector to socialize with his rich parishioners and terrify his poor parishioners with threats of hell. When he encounters adversity—such as when rich and pretty Rosalie Murray, who has been flirting with him consistently, rejects his proposal of marriage—he is devastated and reacts spitefully, threatening to spread rumors damaging to Rosalie's reputation if she tells anyone that he proposed.

By contrast, the curate in Horton, Mr. Weston, is a genuinely religious man who spends much of his free time aiding and comforting poor cottage-dwellers in the village. He reacts to his own emotionally devastating event, the death of his mother, by taking comfort in Christian works of mercy. When he is disappointed in love—Agnes, whom he quietly admires, leaves Horton to start a school with her mother—he doesn't throw a fit like Mr. Hatfield. Instead, he quietly perseveres, gets a new job near to Agnes, courts her, and eventually marries her. The contrast between Mr. Hatfield and Mr. Weston shows that while insincere people like Mr. Hatfield can thrive in religious institutions, only sincere believers like Mr. Weston personal comfort and strength from religious belief.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



ANIMALS

In *Agnes Grey*, animals symbolize the vulnerability of lower-status people to higher-status people in

social hierarchies: just as poorly raised children abuse animals, so poorly raised high-status adults abuse lower-status adults, such as their employees and the poor. Animals first make an important appearance in *Agnes Grey* when Agnes, leaving home to work as a governess for the first time, kisses her pet pigeons goodbye and laments that the family kitten, her “dear little friend,” will have grown into a cat by the time Agnes comes home for Christmas. Agnes's tenderness toward her pets establishes her kindness and models good behavior toward vulnerable animals. By contrast, Agnes's first pupil, seven-year-old Tom Bloomfield, tortures helpless baby birds to death—a

habit he has learned from his father Mr. Bloomfield and his boorish Uncle Robson. Tom's cruelty toward the animals he holds in his power parallels the cruelty that Mr. Bloomfield and Mrs. Bloomfield show to Agnes, their economically dependent employee. They will not allow her to discipline Tom or their other children, even though Tom regularly hits Agnes, yet they blame her and eventually fire her for their children's poor behavior. A similar dynamic plays out in Agnes's second governess job with the Murrays. When her teenage pupil Matilda neglects Snap, a terrier puppy she is supposed to be raising, Agnes takes responsibility for Snap, who grows to love Agnes and to ignore Matilda. Matilda is annoyed by Snap's defection, and so the Murrays sell Snap to a rat-catcher despite Agnes's obvious love for the dog—a sale showing their casual use and abuse of power over both the animals they own and over Agnes. Thus, in *Agnes Grey*, a person's cruelty to animals both symbolizes and predicts their cruelty to vulnerable human beings in their power.



FLOWERS

In *Agnes Grey*, flowers represent the difference between Agnes Grey's beliefs about love and those

of her flirtatious student Rosalie Murray: whereas Agnes believes that love derives from shared values and mutual support, Rosalie thinks of love as the result of a struggle in which a woman “conquers” a man with her charms. When Agnes is missing her loving, religious home while working for the status-obsessed, superficial Murray family, she sees primroses that remind her of home blooming high up in some tree roots. When Agnes tries and fails to reach the primroses by herself, the village curate Mr. Weston stops, picks them for her, and asks her about her favorite flowers. Agnes tells him that her favorite flowers are those that remind her of her loving home. This explanation makes explicit the symbolic link between flowers and love while also foreshadowing that Mr. Weston—with whom Agnes falls in love and eventually marries—will give Agnes a new loving home based on shared moral and religious commitments. In contrast, Rosalie Murray later flirts with the lovesick village rector Mr. Hatfield by toying with a sprig of myrtle (a flowering plant) while he detains her with conversation. When he asks her for the myrtle—symbolically asking for her love—Rosalie refuses to give it to him until he begs for it. After he takes the flower and goes, Rosalie immediately criticizes him to Agnes, revealing that she is only interested in “conquering” Mr. Hatfield, not in loving him herself. Love is, to Rosalie, a game. The different ways Agnes and Rosalie exchange flowers with men thus illustrate their divergent beliefs about what romantic love should be.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Wordsworth Editions edition of *Agnes Grey* published in 1998.

Chapter 1: The Parsonage Quotes

☞ All true histories contain instruction; though, in some, the treasure may be hard to find, and when found, so trivial in quantity, that the dry, shrivelled kernel scarcely compensates for the trouble of cracking the nut. Whether this be the case with my history or not, I am hardly competent to judge. I sometimes think it might prove useful to some, and entertaining to others; but the world may judge for itself.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

This quotation opens the novel *Agnes Grey*. In it, the novel's narrator Agnes refers to "true histories" and then "my history," suggesting that the story she is about to tell readers is factually true. Although this is not literally the case—*Agnes Grey* is a work of fiction—many of the characters and incidents on the novel are based on author Anne Brontë's real experiences working as a governess. As such, this opening implies to readers that they are reading a work of autobiographical fiction and ought to take its depictions of Victorian education and social mores seriously.

In this quotation, Agnes casts herself as an educator and her story as a work of "instruction." Yet she compares stories that contain instruction to nuts with hard shells that contain a "kernel" of edible material. In some cases, the lesson to be learned is like "dry" and "shriveled" food, barely worth consuming. Agnes then claims not to know whether her own story is worth consuming or not. This claim accomplishes two objectives. On the one hand, it primes readers to find a moral or morals in Agnes's story, the "kernel" of learning that she suggests is present in all true histories. On the other hand, it presents Agnes as a humble teacher, not imposing herself on readers but letting them "judge for" themselves the worth of her lesson.

☞ An elegant house and spacious grounds were not to be despised; but she would rather live in a cottage with Richard Grey than in a palace with any other man in the world.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey

Related Themes:

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

Early in the novel, Agnes provides readers with a brief summary of her parents' history: her mother Alice, born into wealth, chose to marry poor clergyman Richard Grey even though her family warned her that such a marriage would lead her to a life of comparative material disadvantage.

The reasoning that Agnes attributes to her mother in choosing to marry Richard illuminates one view of marriage presented by the novel. On the one hand, Agnes's mother thought that wealth—represented by an "elegant house and spacious grounds"—were "not to be despised." That is, Agnes's mother was not an ascetic: she understood and appreciated the value of economic security. Nevertheless, she preferred "a cottage" with the man she loved than "a palace with any other man in the world": that is, while acknowledging the benefits of wealth, she still believed love without wealth was preferable to wealth without love.

Because marriage is one of the few social options available to middle-class Victorian women in the novel, various female characters throughout the novel have to choose whether to marry for wealth, to marry for love, or not to marry and risk loneliness and economic insecurity. Agnes's mother's choice, related at the beginning of the novel, represents one path a Victorian woman can take.

Chapter 2: First Lessons in the Art of Instruction Quotes

☞ "Surely, Tom, you would not strike your sister! I hope I shall never see you do that."

"You will sometimes: I'm obliged to do it now and then to keep her in order."

"But it is not your business to keep her in order, you know, that is for—"

"Well, now go and put on your bonnet."

Related Characters: Agnes Grey, Tom Bloomfield (speaker), Mary Ann Bloomfield

Related Themes:

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes has just taken her first governess job with the Bloomfield family and is spending her first evening with her students, seven-year-old Tom Bloomfield and his younger sister Mary Ann. Tom has just demanded that Agnes come outside to look at his garden. When Mary Ann suggests that Agnes look at her garden too, Tom threatens to hit his sister. Agnes, shocked, scolds Tom and says she hopes he'll "never" strike Mary Ann in her presence. Tom's casual response—that has to hit Mary Ann "to keep her in order"—and his subsequent bossing around of Agnes reveal two power hierarchies in the Bloomfield household that will prevent Agnes from being a successful governess there.

Tom's attitude toward both his younger sister Mary Ann and his older governess Agnes is bossy: he believes that he has the right to order them both around. Implicitly, Tom believes he has this right because he is male, and they are female. Tom may also feel that he has the right to order Agnes around because she is a governess, an employee of the Bloomfield family, whereas Tom is the family heir. That is, Tom believes he outranks Mary Ann and Agnes both in a gender hierarchy and in a socioeconomic hierarchy—and that outranking them justifies callousness and even physical violence toward them "to keep them in order."

Because teaching requires teachers to have a certain amount of authority over their students, Agnes's lack of authority over Tom due to the sexist and classist household she has entered foreshadows her inability to teach him either academic subjects or good behavior.

☛ "Papa knows how I treat them, and he never blames me for it: he says it is just what *he* used to do when *he* was a boy."

Related Characters: Tom Bloomfield (speaker), Agnes Grey, Mr. Bloomfield

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 17

Explanation and Analysis

While Agnes's new pupil Tom Bloomfield is showing her his garden, Agnes spies some strange objects in the grass and asks what they are. Tom explains that they are traps for birds, which he captures and tortures to death. When a horrified Agnes tells Tom that torturing helpless animals is evil, Tom denies it on the grounds that his father Mr.

Bloomfield also used to torture birds to death as a child.

Tom's response to Agnes's criticism reveals a major roadblock in her attempts to teach her pupils good behavior and morals: although the Bloomfields have hired Agnes to teach their children values, they as parents have more power over their children's assumptions, beliefs, and morals than Agnes does. When Agnes's ideas about good behavior conflict with those of employer-parents, the children are overwhelmingly likely to ignore Agnes and follow their parents' example. In general, then, teachers have less power over children's implicit education—and parents have more power—than is generally realized.

Tom's cruelty to animals suggests another, related roadblock in Agnes's attempts to teach him: one of the things that Tom has learned from his parents is cruelty toward creatures lower in the status hierarchy. He is cruel toward birds because they are non-human animals, cruel to his sister Mary Ann because she is a girl, and cruel toward Agnes because she is both female and an employee. The Bloomfield parents encourage their son's cruel status-consciousness, which prevents Agnes as a young, female employee from exercising authority over him, even though she is his teacher.

Chapter 3: A Few More Lessons Quotes

☛ The habitual fear of their father's peevish temper, and the dread of the punishments he was wont to inflict when irritated, kept them generally within bounds in his immediate presence. The girls, too, had some fear of their mother's anger; and the boy might occasionally be bribed to do as she bid him by the hope of reward: but I had no rewards to offer, and as for punishments, I was given to understand, the parents reserved that privilege for themselves; and yet they expected me to keep my pupils in order.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Tom Bloomfield, Mrs. Bloomfield, Mary Ann Bloomfield, Mr. Bloomfield, Fanny Bloomfield

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 21–22

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes is explaining the dysfunctional allocation of authority and responsibility in the Bloomfield household, which prevents her from educating her pupils Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny effectively.

Mr. Bloomfield, the man of the house, keeps the children in

“habitual fear of his peevish temper”—that is, constantly afraid of his anger—because he inflicts “punishments” on them whenever he is “irritated.” Notably, this description implies that Mr. Bloomfield punishes the children according to his mood rather than according to their behavior, thus implicitly teaching the children that the most powerful person in the household has the right to inflict discomfort or cruelty on the less powerful according to his whims. Mrs. Bloomfield, who is lower on the hierarchy than her husband due to her gender, has similarly despotic power over her female children but is reduced to bribing her son, the male heir.

Mr. and Mrs. Bloomfield “reserve the privilege” of punishing their children for themselves—that is to say, though they punish their children semi-arbitrarily to assert their own authority and status within the household, they refuse that “privilege” to Agnes implicitly because she is an employee. Giving Agnes privileges would disrupt the household’s class hierarchy, which the status-conscious Bloomfields do not want to do. Yet Mr. and Mrs. Bloomfield still give Agnes the responsibility of “keep[ing her] pupils in order.” The Bloomfield parents want authority without responsibility, while they insist that Agnes take responsibility without authority—a dysfunctional situation that keeps any of the adults in the household from consistently and fairly regulating the Bloomfield children’s behavior.

Chapter 5: The Uncle Quotes

☝ “Curse me, if I ever saw a nobler little scoundrel than that. He’s beyond petticoat government already: by God! He defies mother, granny, governess, and all! Ha, ha, ha!”

Related Characters: Uncle Robson (speaker), Agnes Grey, Tom Bloomfield, Mrs. Bloomfield

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 37

Explanation and Analysis

Mrs. Bloomfield’s brother, Tom’s Uncle Robson, has given Tom a nest of baby birds to torture to death. Agnes, who has resolved to prevent Tom’s animal cruelty, mercy-kills the birds rather than allowing him to cause the helpless birds protracted agony. Tom, furious, runs to find Uncle Robson and tries to convince him to punish Agnes.

This situation and Uncle Robson’s amused reaction

suggests a disturbing connection between human cruelty toward animals and men’s cruelty toward women. Uncle Robson, who models and encourages Tom’s cruelty toward animals, praises Tom for defying “petticoat government.” A petticoat is an underskirt, a garment commonly worn by Victorian women. Uncle Robson goes on to praise Tom’s disrespect for Tom’s mother Mrs. Bloomfield, his grandmother, and his governess Agnes. As Uncle Robson has taught Tom to torture animals, so he teaches Tom through his encouragement to disrespect women. This parallel suggests that boys who harm animals will grow up to be men who disrespect and even harm women, as in a sexist Victorian society both forms of cruelty are fundamentally a form of higher-status beings abusing their power over lower-status ones.

Chapter 7: Horton Lodge Quotes

☝ I really liked her—when she did not rouse my indignation, or ruffle my temper by too great a display of her faults. These, however, I would fain persuade myself, were rather the effect of her education than her disposition: she had never been perfectly taught the distinction between right and wrong; she had, like her brothers and sisters, been suffered, from infancy, to tyrannise over nurses, governesses, and servants[.]

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Rosalie Murray, Mrs. Murray, Mr. Murray

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 51

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes is summarizing for readers what she has learned about the Murray family during her first two years of working as a governess for them. In this quotation, she is speaking in particular of her oldest pupil, Rosalie Murray.

Agnes’s account of Rosalie suggests that a child’s education by her parents is as important or more important than “her disposition,” i.e. her natural personality, in determining her behavior. Though Agnes “really like[s]” Rosalie’s natural personality, she sees that Rosalie’s parents, Mr. Murray and Mrs. Murray, have allowed her to “tyrannise over nurses, governesses, and servants” from a young age. In other words, Rosalie’s status-conscious family has implicitly taught her that due to her socioeconomic status, she has a right to treat lower-status people such as employees with cruelty and contempt.

Ironically, of course, Rosalie’s parents have farmed out

responsibility for educating Rosalie to one of the lower-status employees—Agnes, a governess—that they have taught their daughter to order around and to scorn. Without intending to, then, the Murray parents have both given Rosalie a bad early education and already undermined Agnes's authority, the very person that they expect to educate their daughter.

Chapter 8: The 'Coming Out' Quotes

☞ “You did not ask me if Mr Richardson were a good, wise, or amiable man.”

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey, Mary, Rosalie Murray

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 59

Explanation and Analysis

When Rosalie asks—demands, really—that Agnes postpone her vacation to be around for the ball where she'll be introduced to society, Agnes refuses on the grounds that she needs to help prepare for and attend her sister Mary's wedding. Agnes's refusal leads Rosalie to question Agnes about Mary's groom-to-be: specifically, his looks, wealth, and age. When Rosalie is horrified to hear that the groom isn't handsome, rich, and young, Agnes rather tartly points out that Rosalie didn't ask whether the groom (Mr. Richardson) was “good, wise, or amiable.”

In this scene, Agnes is attempting to educate Rosalie on what makes a good marriage just as Rosalie enters the marriage market. Whereas Rosalie privileges physical attractiveness and wealth in a prospective husband, Agnes points out that other criteria—such as moral goodness, wisdom, and kindness or “amiability”—are possible. Agnes's criteria show that she has learned from her parents, Richard Grey and Alice Grey, to value love and respect over attraction and social standing. By contrast, Rosalie's mother Mrs. Murray has taught Rosalie to value wealth and rank in a husband above all else.

Unfortunately, Agnes's interventions will not be adequate to undo the lessons that Rosalie has learned for her mother. This will ultimately lead Rosalie to marry for wealth, with unhappy consequences; and Agnes to marry for love, leading to a happy ending.

Chapter 9: The Ball Quotes

☞ “Sir Thomas is young, rich and gay; but an ugly beast, nevertheless; however mamma says I should not mind that after a few months' acquaintance.”

Related Characters: Rosalie Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey, Mary, Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 61

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes has returned from her vacation and her sister Mary's wedding to her employment in the Murray household, where Agnes's pupil Rosalie proceeds to tell her about the ball the Murrays held to introduce 18-year-old Rosalie as a marriageable young woman to society. Rosalie, giving a rundown of the men who admired her at the ball, describes one, Sir Thomas Ashby, as an “ugly beast” but adds that her mother Mrs. Murray has told her she won't “mind that after a few months' acquaintance.”

This rather disturbing quotation foreshadows how Mrs. Murray will encourage her daughter to marry an immoral man for his wealth and rank and so doom Rosalie to unhappiness. Sir Thomas Ashby is “rich” and “gay”—that is, not only wealthy but also cheerful and pleasure-seeking. Though Rosalie values both wealth and fun, she seems to have doubts about Sir Thomas Ashby, describing him as nevertheless an “ugly beast,” a descriptor that seems to encompass both an unattractive physical appearance (“ugly”) and almost inhumanly bad behavior (“beast”).

Mrs. Murray encourages Rosalie to ignore her intuitive reservations about Sir Thomas Ashby, implicitly because he is rich and high-ranking. This foolish encouragement shows how Mrs. Murray, in educating her daughter to value wealth and status over goodness in prospective husbands, ultimately dooms her to unhappiness—as Sir Thomas turns out to be a cruel, drunken, and unfaithful husband.

☞ “But if I could always be young, I would always be single. I should like to enjoy myself thoroughly, and coquet with all the world, till I am on the verge of being called an old maid; and then, to escape the infamy of that, after having made ten thousand conquests, to break all their hearts save one, by marrying some high-born, rich, indulgent husband, whom, on the other hand, fifty ladies were dying to have.”

Related Characters: Rosalie Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey,

Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 62–63

Explanation and Analysis

When Agnes asks her pupil Rosalie Murray which of her admirers she likes best, Rosalie grudgingly admits that she will probably marry Sir Thomas Ashby for the status that comes with his wealth and title—but that she “would always be single” if she “could always be young.” Rosalie’s actual lack of interest in marriage gestures both toward the limited opportunities available to middle-class Victorian women and the bad education she has received from her mother Mrs. Murray, which has taught her how to snare a husband but not how to be a wife.

First, Rosalie does not want to get married, but she feels that “being called an old maid” would constitute “infamy,” i.e. social disgrace. Indeed, Rosalie has some reason to believe that failure to marry would lead to a loss of social status, as Agnes—the unmarried working woman with whom Rosalie has the most contact—is generally treated badly by the people around her due to her being an employee rather than a respectable middle-class wife. Thus, at a young age, Rosalie is being pressured to make a life-long commitment in which she is not genuinely interested due to the sexist constraints of her society.

Second, Rosalie—like many people—seems to derive self-esteem and self-satisfaction from exercising her talents. Unfortunately, her status-obsessed mother Mrs. Murray has encouraged Rosalie to hone only those talents that make her attractive to men. Thus, Rosalie derives her self-esteem from “coquet[ting]”—i.e. flirting—and making “conquests” of men’s hearts. Though marriage may be the nominal end goal of Rosalie’s education, her education has only taught her how to secure a romantic partner—to get to a wedding—and not how to behave as a wife, when flirting with multiple partners is no longer socially acceptable. That is, marriage actually represents the *end* of Rosalie’s socially sanctioned ability to use her education and skillset. And so it makes sense that Rosalie would want to avoid marriage, even as she feels it is ultimately unavoidable.

Chapter 10: The Church Quotes

☞ But now and then he gave us a sermon of a different order—what some would call a very good one; but sunless and severe: representing the Deity as a terrible taskmaster, rather than a benevolent father. Yet, as I listened, I felt inclined to think the man was sincere in all he said: he must have changed his views, and become decidedly religious; gloomy and austere, yet still devout. But such illusions were usually dissipated, on coming out of church, by hearing his voice in jocund colloquy with some of the Melthams or Greens, or, perhaps, the Murrays themselves[.]

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Mr. Hatfield

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 65

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes is describing the rector at the village church nearest the Murrays’ estate, Mr. Hatfield. Her opinion of Mr. Hatfield reinforces the implicit argument, found elsewhere in the novel, that social hierarchies lead to cruelty of higher-status people toward lower-status people. It also introduces religious hypocrisy of the higher classes as one of the novel’s major themes.

Agnes’s description of Mr. Hatfield’s sermons implicitly contrasts her religious viewpoints with his. When she says that “some people” would call Mr. Hatfield’s “sunless and severe”—that is, dark and harsh—sermons as “very good,” she implies that unlike “some people,” *she* does not feel that Christianity shouldn’t be as Mr. Hatfield portrays it. Similarly, when she says that Mr. Hatfield describes God “as a terrible taskmaster, rather than a benevolent father,” she implies that *she* thinks of God as a good, kind father and not, as Mr. Hatfield would have it, a frightening overlord holding his worshippers’ feet to the fire.

Readers can extrapolate that Agnes thinks that Mr. Hatfield’s religious views are excessively punishment-focused and cruel—and that, given his “jocund” (jolly) conversations with his richer parishioners like the Murrays, the impressions that he gives of being “decidedly religious” during his fire-and-brimstone sermons are “illusions.” Rather than being religiously sincere, Mr. Hatfield uses his religious authority and status to terrify his lower-status parishioners while cozying up to his higher-status parishioners. Thus, the character of Mr. Hatfield marries the tendency of social hierarchies to create cruelty with a disturbing religious hypocrisy.

Chapter 11: The Cottagers Quotes

☞☞ Habitual associates are known to exercise a great influence over each other's minds and manners. Those whose actions are for ever before our eyes, whose words are ever in our ears, will naturally lead us, albeit against our will, slowly, gradually, imperceptibly, perhaps, to act and speak as they do.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Mr. Weston

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 77

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes is explaining to readers why she is so grateful to have heard about the new curate Mr. Weston's good deeds toward the poor villagers around the Murrays' estate. She believes that "habitual associates" (that is, people who spend a great deal of time together) affect one another's "minds and manners" (their thoughts, opinions, and behaviors). Moreover, she believes that these effects can occur "even against our will": in other words, the people with whom someone spends time will influence a person's thoughts and behaviors, even if they consciously disapprove of those people.

Agnes consciously disapproves of her employers, the Murrays, but she also spends all her time with them, and so she fears that she will gradually become more like them to her own detriment. Mr. Weston, by contrast, offers a good social influence to counteract the bad influence of the Murrays. As such, Agnes is grateful for him.

The quotation reflects on the novel's representation both of education and of marriage. Previously, the novel has portrayed parents as more important than teachers in teaching children their values and behaviors. While in other places the novel implies that this is because parents tend to have higher status than educator-employees and so more authority over children, here the novel additionally suggests that children are simply around their parents more, and so they're more likely to be influenced by them. Additionally, because spouses are likely to be around each other a great deal, this quotation suggests that people should marry partners they love and morally admire. They should do this, the novel implies, not only for their happiness but also to preserve their own characters against degrading influences.

Chapter 13: The Primroses Quotes

☞☞ As for the primroses, I kept two of them in a glass in my room until they were completely withered, and the housemaid threw them out; and the petals of the other I pressed between the leaves of my Bible—I have them still, and mean to keep them always.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey, Mr. Weston, Rosalie Murray

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

As Agnes is walking home from church, she sees some primroses—flowers that remind her of her northern English home village—high up in the roots of a tree. She attempts to pluck them but can't reach them. Mr. Weston, seeing her difficulty, picks them for her. Afterwards, Agnes "presse[s]" one "between the leaves of [her] Bible."

Flowers conventionally represent romantic love, and the interaction between Agnes and Mr. Weston surrounding the primroses thus characterizes their romance. Agnes wants primroses, flowers that remind her of home: symbolically, then, she wants love that reminds her of the mutually supportive love between her good, wise, religious parents, Richard Grey and Alice Grey. Yet unlike flirtatious Rosalie Murray, for example, Agnes does not consciously seek to snare a romantic partner who will give her what she wants—rather, she tries unsuccessfully to get the flowers that represent love and happiness by herself. Mr. Weston, seeing her struggle, is attracted by what she values (true love, religion, home)—and becomes the vehicle by which she gets what she wants.

Agnes presses the primroses Mr. Weston gives her into her Bible, symbolizing how shared religious commitments and values undergird the romantic pair's growing affection and esteem for each other. Agnes's resolution to "keep [the primroses] always" symbolizes her eternal commitment to her love. Thus, this early scene in which Mr. Weston gives Agnes flowers both foreshadows and symbolizes their entire romance.

Chapter 14: The Rector Quotes

💬 “[W]hy, you must allow me some share of female vanity: I don’t pretend to be without that most essential attribute of our sex[.]”

Related Characters: Rosalie Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey, Mrs. Murray, Mr. Murray, Mr. Hatfield

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

Rosalie Murray has just rejected a proposal from the rector Mr. Hatfield. Describing her interactions with Mr. Hatfield, Rosalie explains to a shocked, disapproving Agnes why she is so pleased with herself for having broken Mr. Hatfield’s heart: his emotional devastation appeals to her “female vanity.” Notably, Rosalie claims that vanity is the “most essential attribute of our sex.” In other words, she is saying that vanity or excessive ego is the defining attribute of women in general.

Rosalie certainly did not learn this belief from Agnes, so the novel implies that she must have picked it up from either her parents or from the surrounding culture. Rosalie’s willingness to cause Mr. Hatfield—and other men—extreme emotional pain just to get an ego boost reveals the poor moral education that she has received from her family and from society. Then, her justification of that willingness based on sexist stereotypes about female vanity shows the ways that internalized sexism can warp women’s beliefs and behaviors.

Chapter 15: The Walk Quotes

💬 I thought of the poor man and his one lamb, and the rich man with his thousand flocks; and I dreaded I knew not what for Mr Weston, independently of my own blighted hopes.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Mr. Weston, Rosalie Murray, Mr. Hatfield

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 103

Explanation and Analysis

Rosalie Murray, bored without admirers now that she has turned down Mr. Hatfield’s proposal, decides to conquer Mr. Weston’s heart—without, however, having any real romantic interest in Mr. Weston. When Agnes, who does

have a real romantic interest in Mr. Weston, realizes what Rosalie is doing, she thinks of “the poor man with his one lamb, and the rich man with his thousand flocks.”

Agnes is alluding to the Bible here: in 2 Samuel 12:1–4, the prophet Nathan tells a parable about a rich man who has many livestock and his poor neighbor who owns a single lamb, which he loves. When the rich man receives a visitor, he steals his poor neighbor’s beloved lamb and slaughters it to make a meal for his visitor rather than drawing on his own flocks. The prophet Nathan tells this parable to King David to condemn David, who already has many legal wives, for stealing Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah the Hittite.

This allusion implicitly compares Rosalie to David, a high-status person occupying a position of economic and romantic privilege who chooses to deprive a lower-status person of their single beloved companion. Agnes is suggesting that Rosalie’s behavior is fundamentally greedy and cruel—both toward Agnes and toward Mr. Weston. In using a Biblical allusion to express her tortured feelings, Agnes also implies that she is a fundamentally better match for Mr. Weston, a clergyman, than Rosalie, who displays no real interest in religion.

Chapter 17: Confessions Quotes

💬 If the mind be but well cultivated, and the heart well disposed, no one ever cares for the exterior. So said the teachers of our childhood; and so say we to the children of the present day. All very judicious and proper, no doubt; but are such assertions supported by actual experience?

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Mr. Weston, Rosalie Murray

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 107

Explanation and Analysis

Pretty, flirtatious Rosalie Murray has decided to capture Mr. Weston’s heart as a way of bolstering her ego and keeping herself entertained despite having no genuine interest in Mr. Weston as a prospective husband. Agnes, who does genuinely love Mr. Weston, begins examining herself in the mirror and, judging herself plain, feels discouraged.

Agnes is discouraged because of a clash between what “the teachers of [her] childhood” have told her about beauty and what she has learned from “actual experience.” Her childhood teachers taught her that a “well cultivated”

(educated) intellect and a “well disposed” (kind) heart matter much more than one’s “exterior,” or their appearance. Having been educated in this way, Agnes herself cares more about other people’s minds and behavior than she does about their looks. This partly explains her love for Mr. Weston, who is thoughtful, kind, and charitable but not particularly handsome.

Yet Agnes’s “actual experience” has taught her that a woman with a pretty “exterior” will receive positive attention even if she fails to cultivate her mind or behave kindly to others: witness the many men who fall in love with beautiful but cruel Rosalie Murray. As such, Agnes is realizing that her culture’s sexist obsession with women’s physical attractiveness often undermines the intellectual and moral values the culture claims to support—placing plain, good Agnes, who takes those values seriously, at a serious disadvantage in the marriage market.

☞ [B]esides my hope in God, my only consolation was in thinking that, though he knew it not, I was more worthy of his love than Rosalie Murray, charming and engaging as she was; for I could appreciate his excellence, which she could not: I would devote my life to the promotion of his happiness; she would destroy his happiness for the momentary gratification of her own vanity.

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Mr. Weston, Rosalie Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby, Mr. Hatfield

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 113

Explanation and Analysis

Rosalie Murray, though engaged to Sir Thomas Ashby, has been trying to steal the clergyman Mr. Weston’s heart to bolster her ego and to keep herself entertained. Additionally, Agnes, who loves Mr. Weston, has heard that he is likely to leave the village because he cannot get along with his colleague and fellow clergyman Mr. Hatfield at the village church. Tormented by the thought of losing Mr. Weston either due to Rosalie’s flirtation or to Mr. Hatfield’s hostility, Agnes comforts herself with “hope in God” and with her judgment that she is more worthy of Mr. Weston than her romantic rival, Rosalie.

The way that Agnes comforts herself reveals that she has internal resources Rosalie Murray lacks, despite Rosalie’s higher social status and greater beauty. First, as a sincere religious believer, Agnes can find comfort in Christianity’s

promises of ultimate happiness with God in the afterlife, which Rosalie—who seems to attend church solely for social reasons—cannot do. Second, Agnes’s self-esteem ultimately relies on her own judgment about whether she is “worthy,” not others’ judgment: she does not need Mr. Weston to know her worth in order to believe in it herself. By contrast, Rosalie derives her self-esteem from male admiration and is therefore fundamentally dependent upon men.

Thus Agnes’s religious beliefs and her moral education ultimately provide her with internal resources that help her weather disappointment and pain—internal resources that Rosalie Murray never learns to develop.

Chapter 18: Mirth and Mourning Quotes

☞ “Tilly, though she would have made a fine lad, was not quite what a young lady ought to be[.]”

Related Characters: Mr. Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey, Rosalie Murray, Matilda Murray, Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 117

Explanation and Analysis

After Rosalie Murray marries Sir Thomas Ashby, Rosalie’s mother Mrs. Murray begins to concentrate on the marriageability of her younger daughter, Matilda. Up to this point, Mrs. Murray has deplored but allowed Matilda’s stereotypically “masculine” interests in horseback riding, hunting with dogs, and learning to swear from her father Mr. Murray and from his male servants. With Rosalie married off, however, Mrs. Murray begins imposing her ideals of femininity on Matilda—with the consent of Mr. Murray, who acknowledges that “Tilly” (a nickname for Matilda) is “not quite what a young lady ought to be” even “though she would have made a fine lad.”

Mr. Murray’s acknowledgment that Matilda has the virtues of a “fine lad” but is not “what a young lady ought to be” illustrates the limitations placed on Victorian women’s activities and ambitions. Everyone agrees that Matilda has good qualities; even Agnes, who finds Matilda’s “masculine” cursing horrible, acknowledges that Matilda is an honest and energetic young person. Yet Matilda’s good qualities and outdoorsy interests aren’t particularly suited to ensnaring a wealthy and high-status husband, the only ambition that status-obsessed Mrs. Murray will allow her

“young lady” daughters to pursue. Thus, Matilda is trapped and made miserable by a society that thinks her virtues and interests should be reserved for “lad[s].”

“It seems unnatural: but some people think rank and wealth the chief good; and, if they can secure that for their children, they think they have done their duty.”

“True: but is it not strange that persons of experience, who have been married themselves, should judge so falsely?”

Related Characters: Agnes Grey, Mr. Weston (speaker), Rosalie Murray, Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 119

Explanation and Analysis

After Rosalie Murray marries Sir Thomas Ashby, Agnes and Mr. Weston meet by chance and end up discussing whether Rosalie will be happy in her marriage. As both Agnes and Mr. Weston have heard alarming rumors about Sir Thomas Ashby's immorality, both worry that Rosalie will be miserable—and both blame Rosalie's mother for encouraging the marriage despite having heard the same alarming rumors about Sir Thomas Ashby. The exchange between Agnes and Mr. Weston demonstrates their shared values, foreshadowing their future happy marriage.

Agnes judges it “unnatural” that “some people,” including Mrs. Murray, “think rank and wealth the chief good.” This judgment communicates to Mr. Weston that Agnes is relatively uninterested in status or money, which opens the door to a romance between them, as Mr. Weston is a middle-class clergyman with an existing but limited salary. When Mr. Weston replies that it's “strange” that married people “should judge so falsely” about what makes a happy marriage, he communicates to Agnes that he agrees with her implicitly conveyed values: wealth and rank really aren't important. This opens the door to their future romance wider, since Agnes is a low-status governess from a respectable but impoverished family.

Thus, through a shared negative judgment on Mrs. Murray's behavior with respect to Rosalie, Agnes and Mr. Weston subtly communicate to each other that they have a shared conception of marriage and shared disinterest in chasing money or status—values that will form the basis of their own future happy marriage.

Chapter 19: The Letter Quotes

“[I]f he married a richer wife, misfortunes and trials would no doubt have come upon him still; while I am egotist enough to imagine that no other woman could have cheered him through that so well: not that I am superior to the rest, but I was made for him, and he for me[.]”

Related Characters: Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey (speaker), Agnes Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey, Rosalie Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 124

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes's father Richard Grey has died after a long illness. The day following his funeral, Agnes's mother receives a letter from her estranged, wealthy father offering to support her economically and write Agnes and Mary into his will—if she will admit that she made a mistake in marrying poor clergyman Richard Grey against her family's wishes and admit regrets. This letter exemplifies the cruelties that infest social hierarchies throughout the novel: Agnes's grandfather, a high-status and wealthy man, attempts to coerce his lower-status, impoverished daughter into forswearing her loving marriage immediately after her beloved husband has died.

Upon reading the letter, Agnes's mother explains to her daughters how she plans to respond to her father and why. Her response implicitly rebukes her father for believing that money and status are more important to marriage than love. In this response, she claims that even rich people must face “misfortunes and trials” from time to time—that is, wealth is not a protection against bad luck or pain. Therefore, she does not feel that she wronged her beloved Richard in marrying him without financial support from her family (which they withheld because they disapproved of the marriage). On the other hand, Agnes's mother does believe that because she and her husband loved each other, she was particularly well suited to “cheer[] [Richard] through” the inevitable “misfortunes and trials of life.” In sum, Agnes's mother is arguing that wealth cannot ward off pain, while love can make pain easier to bear.

The novel implicitly endorses this argument in the contrasting fates of Agnes and her pupil Rosalie Murray. Agnes marries Mr. Weston, a clergyman with a small income, whom she loves and respects. Agnes ends up very happy. Rosalie, on the other hand, marries Sir Thomas Ashby, a rich and titled man whom she neither loves nor respects—and she ends up miserable.

Chapter 20: The Farewell Quotes

☞ We often pity the poor, because they have no leisure to mourn their departed relatives, and necessity obliges them to labour through their severest afflictions: but is not active employment the best remedy for overwhelming sorrow—the surest antidote for despair?

Related Characters: Agnes Grey (speaker), Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey, Mary, Mrs. Murray

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 125

Explanation and Analysis

Agnes's father, Richard Grey, has died. Agnes's mother, rather than become a dependent in her oldest daughter Mary's household, decides to open a small school with Agnes. Agnes, reflecting on how their English Victorian culture would view her mother's situation, concludes that many would "pity" her mother for having to "labour through" her grief—but that this pity is misplaced because work is "the best remedy for overwhelming sorrow." Whether or not Agnes intends it as such, her claim that hard work mitigates grief and "despair" is an implicit critique of middle-class women's positions in Victorian society.

Throughout the novel, readers have seen Agnes treated with callousness, cruelty, and contempt because she is a woman who works outside the home. Middle-class wives like Agnes's employer Mrs. Murray hustle their daughters into marriages with wealthy men presumably because the leisure that an advantageous marriage affords is far more socially respected than work. Yet work is not just a necessary evil for women without money: it is a "remedy" and an "antidote" to pain—of which middle-class Victorian women are frequently deprived by social norms that keep them inside the home. Thus, perhaps unintentionally, Agnes's thoughts on labor and grief imply a proto-feminist argument for allowing women to work without social penalties.

Chapter 21: The School Quotes

☞ Alas! how far the promise of anticipation exceeds the pleasure of possession!

Related Characters: Rosalie Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey, Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 133

Explanation and Analysis

Rosalie Murray—now Rosalie Ashby—has returned from her honeymoon with her new husband Sir Thomas Ashby and taken up residence in his estate, Ashby Park. The "anticipation" of owning Ashby Park helped convince Rosalie to accept Sir Thomas Ashby's proposal, but when Rosalie writes to Agnes inviting Agnes to visit her, she mentions that that anticipation "exceeds the pleasure of possession." In other words, Rosalie enjoyed the idea of owning Ashby Park prior to her marriage far more than she enjoys actually owning Ashby Park now that she's married.

Rosalie's admission that "the pleasure of possession" has disappointed her underscores two of the novel's morals: the importance of a sound moral education and the centrality of real love to marriage. Rosalie's mother gave her a bad moral education in childhood, teaching her that wealth and status were central to happiness. Though Agnes tried to teach Rosalie otherwise, she arrived too late in Rosalie's development and had too little authority to counteract Mrs. Murray's teachings. Thus, Rosalie's bad education led her to overestimate how happy owning an estate would make her, leading to her disappointment after marriage.

Rosalie is explicitly talking about Ashby Park when she expresses the disappointment of her "anticipation," but she is likely also talking about her husband Sir Thomas Ashby as well. Rosalie supposed that marrying a rich, high-ranking man was her best option for happiness—another bad lesson she learned from her mother. Experience with marriage is now teaching her that Sir Thomas's wealth and rank don't outweigh his fundamental personal unpleasantness. Implicitly, then, Rosalie's quotation suggests that while women may think a rich, high-status husband will make them happy, they would be wiser to marry a man they love and can admire.

Chapter 22: The Visit Quotes

☞ "It's the husband's part to please the wife, not hers to please him; and if he isn't satisfied with her as she is—and thankful to possess her too—he isn't worthy of her, that's all."

Related Characters: Rosalie Murray (speaker), Agnes Grey, Agnes's Mother/Alice Grey, Agnes's Father/Richard Grey, Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 140**Explanation and Analysis**

Agnes is visiting her former pupil Rosalie Murray, now Rosalie Ashby, at the estate of her husband Sir Thomas Ashby. When the miserable Rosalie reveals to Agnes that Sir Thomas Ashby's conversation is objectionable and that he drinks too much, Agnes suggests that Rosalie use her own education and accomplishments to induce her husband to behave better. Rosalie's scornful response—that "it's the husband's part to please the wife, not hers to please him"—highlights the differences in Agnes's and Rosalie's views on marriage, which derive from the different educations they received from their family.

Rosalie's mother wanted Rosalie to marry the wealthiest, highest-ranking man possible. As such, she encouraged Rosalie to learn only those skills that made her attractive to men. Rosalie thus learned to see herself as ornamental, a pretty prize for men to win with their money and title. She never learned to see herself as a partner or helper to her husband, or for that matter, a person whose thoughts and interests matter. Therefore, she reacts with incredulity to Agnes's idea that she could educate her husband in better behavior and encourage him to change.

By contrast, Agnes learned from her poor but loving and mutually supportive parents' example that spouses should help each other through adversity. Agnes does not see wives as ornamental prizes but as central participants in family and household life. As such, the advice that Agnes gives to Rosalie makes perfect sense if one has Agnes's views on wives and marriage. But Rosalie, who was taught different views, will never take that advice.

Chapter 23: The Park Quotes

💬 "But you knew what he was before you married him."

"No; I only thought so: I did not half know him really. I know you warned me against it, and I wish I had listened to you: but it's too late to regret that now. And besides, mamma ought to have known better than either of us, and she never said anything against it—quite the contrary."

Related Characters: Agnes Grey, Rosalie Murray (speaker), Mrs. Murray, Sir Thomas Ashby

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 142**Explanation and Analysis**

While Agnes is visiting Rosalie at Rosalie's new home, Ashby Park, Rosalie admits to Agnes that she hates her new husband Sir Thomas Ashby. When a shocked Agnes objects that Rosalie knew "what he was"—that is, that she was fully aware of what his character and behavior were like—before she married him, Rosalie explains that this wasn't really the case. That Rosalie only learns her husband's vices after she has legally bound herself to him for life shows the perils of girls' education and of women's limited roles in the Victorian era.

Rosalie, a sheltered middle-class Victorian girl in a rural village, could not fully have anticipated her older, aristocratic husband's alcohol abuse or sexual promiscuity. Even Agnes, who "warned" Rosalie not to marry Sir Thomas Ashby, didn't necessarily know what his objectionable behavior consisted of. She only foresaw that his reputation for immorality might mean he'd make a bad husband. Rosalie is correct that her mother, an older, married woman, probably "ought to have known better" than either Rosalie herself or Agnes, but Mrs. Murray was too convinced that marriage to a rich man constituted happiness for a young woman to warn her daughter of the potential pitfalls. Thus, Rosalie's inexperience and her mother's obsession with marriage as the apex of female achievement helped doom her to a miserable marriage.

Chapter 24: The Sands Quotes

💬 "I am not so presumptuous as to believe that [...] though you tell me; but if it were so, I am rather particular in my notions of a companion for life, and perhaps I might not find one to suit me among the ladies you mention."

Related Characters: Mr. Weston (speaker), Agnes Grey

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 147**Explanation and Analysis**

Agnes has unexpectedly encountered Mr. Weston walking on the beach in the coastal town where she and her mother have set up a school. He walks her home, and as they talk, Mr. Weston describes his improved work situation and mentions that the only thing he needs to complete his happiness is a wife. When an embarrassed Agnes blurts that he'll no doubt meet many candidates in the surrounding areas, Mr. Weston mentions that he's "not so presumptuous as to believe" that he'll have his pick of brides—but also that he's "rather particular in [his] notions of a companion for life."

Mr. Weston's subtly flirtatious response indicates his ongoing romantic interest in Agnes and implies the reasons that he has fallen in love with her. When he says that perhaps he won't prefer any woman "among the ladies [Agnes] mention[s]," it cannot escape the reader's notice that Agnes has not mentioned herself. Mr. Weston is implying that he isn't interested in women other than Agnes. Moreover, when he says that he's "particular," it suggests that he has strong values and high standards for

behavior—and that Agnes, unlike many of the shallow, superficial, and cruel people they both knew in Horton village, meets his high standards. In other words, he's implying that he both loves and admires her.

Thus, Mr. Weston's subtle flirtation with Agnes emphasizes that in *Agnes Grey*, lasting marriages are built on love, mutual esteem, and shared values.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1: THE PARSONAGE

Though Agnes believes that all true stories have a lesson to teach; some teach a lot, some only a little. She isn't sure how much her story has to teach, but—having changed her subjects' names to protect their anonymity—she'll let her audience judge.

Agnes's mother, a squire's daughter, decided to marry Richard Grey, a clergyman with a small personal property and a modest income. She persisted even though her alarmed family warned her that she would have to give up her carriage and maid. Her father threatened to disown her, thinking that would stop the marriage. It didn't: Richard Grey wanted to marry Agnes's mother, of whom he thought highly, whether or not she had money, while she would rather work than give up Richard.

Agnes's mother and Richard have six children, of which two—Agnes and her older sister Mary—survive. Agnes and Mary are homeschooled by their educated parents, so they rarely interact with the outside world. Though their mother never seems to regret marrying Richard, Richard—a melancholy man—worries about how much she gave up and often tries to figure out how to increase his wealth, though not by spending less. He likes to buy his family good clothes and give money to poor people.

A friend of Richard's convinces him to invest in the friend's merchant business, claiming that Richard will make double on the investment. Richard sells part of his inheritance to fund the business, and the merchant sets out. Unfortunately, the merchant's ship wrecks, the merchant drowns, and Richard's investment is lost. Richard takes the disaster hard, blaming himself for worsening Agnes's mother's situation, and his health suffers. The family sells its carriage and pony, lets go all but one servant, and tries to save on food and coal.

The novel's narrator Agnes heavily implies that she is telling her story to teach her readers something, which foreshadows both that the novel will have a moral or morals and that education will be a thematically important component of the plot.



Middle-class women in Victorian society had few options for employment. As such, women like Agnes's mother, a squire's daughter, were economically dependent on their families of origin or their husbands. A woman who wanted to marry a poor man could find herself impoverished if her family disapproved of the marriage and cut her off. Using Agnes's mother as an example, the novel thus illustrates how middle-class Victorian woman sometimes had to choose between love and economic security in marriage.



Agnes's mother's happiness in her marriage to poor clergyman Richard Grey suggests that she made the right decision in choosing love over economic comfort, despite Richard's guilt at her having to make such a choice.



Richard Grey makes a risky investment hoping to improve his wife's economic comfort—and the Grey family ends up worse than before. This outcome implies that so long as a family is economically stable, it ought not to take risks seeking more money than it needs—a loving home environment is, perhaps, better for a happy life than riches.



Agnes wants to work around the house, but her active, competent mother babies her, preferring that she study rather than help. One day, Agnes's mother suggests that Mary sell drawings and paintings to an art dealer. When Agnes expresses a desire to contribute too, her mother suggests that she make drawings as well. But Agnes proposes her own idea: to work as a governess. When her mother laughs, Agnes explains that she knows enough to teach small children, whom she adores. She appeals to her mother to let her try.

When Agnes's mother exclaims that Agnes is a child herself, Agnes points out that she's older than 18. She can work—she just hasn't had the chance. When Richard walks in and hears the discussion, he laughs at Agnes too, but then he tears up. Agnes's parents conclude that they neither want nor need Agnes to leave the home. Yet Agnes keeps thinking how good it would be to teach children good morals, to earn money, and to show her family what she's capable of. After a few days, she convinces her dubious parents to consent to her plan and gets a job with the Bloomfields, acquaintances of her father's sister.

Agnes, though hopeful about the job, is sad to leave home: she kisses her favorite pet **pigeons** and thinks how much bigger the kitten will be when she returns home for Christmas. The morning she leaves, she says goodbye to her family, gets into a rented coach, and starts sobbing. As the coach drives away, she looks back at her village and prays for all who live there.

Agnes's desire to help support her family suggests both her loving generosity and her resolve to exercise her talents. Notably, Victorian society gives women relatively few outlets for exercising their talents and supporting themselves: while trying to think of ways to support themselves, the Grey women can come up with only selling art or becoming educators of some kind.



Agnes's resolve to become a governess emphasizes her desire to exercise her talents in a society that provides limited outlets for middle-class women's energy. Meanwhile, her idealization of the role of governess suggests that she sees educating children—particularly in good behavior and values—as a genuinely worthwhile use of her time and skill.



Agnes's tenderness toward her pet pigeons and the family kitten both shows her love for animals and implicitly models how the novel thinks people should treat creatures dependent on them: namely, with gentleness and respect.



CHAPTER 2: FIRST LESSONS IN THE ART OF INSTRUCTION

Agnes's carriage ride, on this September day, is long and cold. Nevertheless, when she arrives at the Bloomfields', she wishes the ride were longer: she is nervous to introduce herself due to her lack of social experience. Yet she expects to get along with the children, she hopes Mrs. Bloomfield will be nice, and she plans not to interact with Mr. Bloomfield. She enters the house and greets Mrs. Bloomfield, a tall, dark-haired, cold woman—though she focuses so hard on controlling her nerves that her responses are slow.

Mrs. Bloomfield gives Agnes a minute to compose herself in her new room, during which Agnes notices in the mirror that her clothes are muddy and her face purple with cold. She tries to neaten herself and goes to the dining room, where Mrs. Bloomfield watches her struggle to eat a tough beefsteak for lunch with hands so chilled she can barely use her cutlery. Then Mrs. Bloomfield ushers Agnes into the sitting room and summons the children, who—Mrs. Bloomfield says—are behind on their education but intelligent, especially her spirited and scrupulously honest son Tom.

Agnes has learned enough from her own homeschool education that she believes she has the skills to teach young children. Yet her rather isolated, protective parents have accidentally prevented her from learning the social mores that would help her navigate employment outside the home. This gap in Agnes's education shows the importance of parents' choices to their children's learning.



Mrs. Bloomfield, watching Agnes struggle to eat with frozen hands, offers her new employee neither sympathy nor help—an omission that suggests Mrs. Bloomfield will not be the kind, welcoming employer that Agnes had hoped.



Seven-year-old Tom and his sister Mary Ann enter the room with their little sisters, almost-four-year-old Fanny and toddler Harriet. Agnes tries to talk to the children, though Mrs. Bloomfield's presence makes her shy. The children seem lively, though Agnes notices with disapproval that Mary Ann is vain and attention-seeking. When Mrs. Bloomfield asks Tom to kiss her and then show Agnes the schoolroom, Tom refuses to kiss his mother but says he'll show Agnes.

In the school room, Mary Ann shows Agnes her doll and chatters about all its clothes and accessories until Tom tells her to be quiet so he can show Agnes his rocking-horse. For 10 minutes, Tom demands that Agnes observe "how manfully" he whips and spurs his horse. In the end, Agnes praises Mary Ann's doll and Tom's riding but says she hopes Tom won't whip and spur a real **horse**. Tom says he certainly will. Agnes, disturbed, hopes to teach him better later.

Tom orders Agnes to put on her bonnet so he can show her his garden. When Mary Ann says they should look at hers too, Tom threatens her with his fist. Agnes tells Tom she hopes she'll never see him hit his sister, but Tom says she will—he must, to keep Mary Ann under control. Agnes points out that it isn't Tom's job to control his sister, but Tom just demands that Agnes follow him. Agnes decides to go along with it because she's only just met him.

In Tom's garden, Agnes notices objects in the grass and asks what they are. Tom says he uses them to catch **birds**, which he tortures and kills. When Agnes tells him that that's evil behavior because birds can feel too, Tom says that he can't feel what he does to the birds. When Agnes suggests that he might feel it in hell if he doesn't stop torturing animals, Tom says Mr. Bloomfield used to torture birds as a boy and that his Uncle Robson has praised him for it, so it can't be evil. Agnes says she still thinks it is—and tells herself that she'll stop Tom from doing it in the future.

In the previous section, Mrs. Bloomfield praised her children's virtues, yet immediately upon meeting Agnes, Mary Ann acts vain, and Tom disobeys his mother. The difference between Mrs. Bloomfield's description of her children and their real behavior may foreshadow trouble for Agnes, as Agnes will be tasked with responding to bad behavior from the children that their mother refuses to recognize.



It is unclear at this point where seven-year-old Tom learned that whipping and spurring horses was "manful[ly]," but his behavior suggests that someone has taught him to view abusing creatures under his power as a sign of masculine strength. Agnes, who loves animals, immediately resolves to correct Tom's cruelty toward animals—showing how central lessons in values are to her conception of her job.



Tom has learned from somewhere that he can and should threaten animals and his younger sister with violence to control them. According to this attitude, higher-status creatures (human beings and boys) have the right to treat lower-status creatures (animals and girls) with physical cruelty. This attitude may have alarming implications for Tom's treatment of women later in his life. Moreover, his bossy attitude toward Agnes suggests that he sees Agnes as lower status because she is an employee and a woman even though she is an adult and his teacher, which foreshadows problems for Agnes in attempting to educate him.



Here readers learn that Tom's animal cruelty is not merely hypothetical, directed only toward rocking horses and other inanimate objects: he tortures captured birds to death. His father and uncle have modeled and reinforced this behavior, a revelation indicating the importance of older relatives to teaching children values. Agnes makes no headway when she tries to appeal to Tom's empathy by explaining that the birds feel pain or when she threatens Tom with religious punishment. Her failure to get through to him suggests that Tom has been poorly educated in empathy and religion. It also suggests that Tom will feel free to disregard what Agnes says if it contradicts his father or uncle because she, a female employee, is lower status than they.



Tom shows Agnes his **mole**-traps and weasel-traps. Agnes indulges him, hoping to make friends and so exert a positive influence on him. But while she notices cleverness in Tom, she doesn't find the goodness that Mrs. Bloomfield mentioned. By the time they reenter the house, it's time to eat. After the children go to bed, Mrs. Bloomfield warns Agnes not to discuss any flaws her children have with anyone but her. Agnes interprets this to mean that she ought not mention the children's flaws at all. After a cold supper, the women go to bed—Agnes thinking that Mrs. Bloomfield is not at all nice like she had hoped.

Tom's traps for rodents as well as birds imply that torturing and killing animals is his major amusement—further suggesting that his father and uncle have drummed into him his right to harm supposedly inferior creatures. Meanwhile, when Agnes realizes that Mrs. Bloomfield doesn't want to hear about her children's flaws, it suggests that Agnes may have no allies in the Bloomfield household in attempting to improve the children's behavior.



CHAPTER 3: A FEW MORE LESSONS

The next day in the school room, Agnes discovers that Tom is clever but lazy, while Mary Ann is both lazy and almost illiterate. After managing to teach them a little, Agnes takes them outside before their midday meal—only to discover that the children order her around. They insist on playing in a dirty, wet well on the lawn despite Agnes ordering them repeatedly to stop—only for Mr. Bloomfield to ride past, criticize “Miss Grey” for his children's dirtiness, and ride on. Agnes is unpleasantly surprised by his rude tone.

When Tom and Mary Ann order Agnes around, it implies that they have learned from their parents to view Agnes as a mere employee and thus not as someone they need to respect or obey. By criticizing Agnes rather than his children for his children's dirty and disobedient behavior, Mr. Bloomfield models disrespect for Agnes to his children and thus further undermines her.



Later, Agnes eats lunch with Mr. Bloomfield, Mrs. Bloomfield, and the children. Mr. Bloomfield, a thin man in his 30s, spends the meal complaining about first the mutton and then the beef. When he asks what's for dinner, he ends up harshly criticizing his wife for not knowing what kind of fish the cook has bought. Mrs. Bloomfield snaps back at him. When the meal ends, Agnes—embarrassed—is glad to flee.

Though the Bloomfields are clearly wealthier than the Greys, Mr. and Mrs. Bloomfield do not seem to have the kind of mutually supportive marriage that Agnes's parents share—another detail hinting that love is better than wealth for producing happiness.



As days pass and Agnes comes to know the children better, her work gets worse. The children fear Mr. Bloomfield, who punishes them when he's angry. The girls also fear Mrs. Bloomfield, though Tom will only obey his mother when she bribes him. Yet the Bloomfields have forbidden Agnes from punishing their children, and she has nothing with which to bribe them. Moreover, the children have no longing for praise, and they don't fear upsetting Agnes.

Implicitly, Mr. and Mrs. Bloomfield don't want Agnes to punish the children because giving Agnes authority over the children would disrupt the social hierarchy in which the children are future “masters” and “mistresses” while Agnes is a mere employee. Yet by insisting on this classist hierarchy, Mr. and Mrs. Bloomfield hobble Agnes's attempts to teach their children anything.



Tom, a little tyrant, hits his sisters and Agnes. Agnes doesn't hit back—she has discovered that, contrary to Mrs. Bloomfield's beliefs, he sometimes lies and would likely exaggerate the incident to his parents. Instead, she holds him down until he stops hitting. Yet often he simply refuses to learn, and she has no power to punish him. She tries to reason with the children, praise them when they're good, and criticize them proportionately but not angrily when they're bad. None of these tactics work.

Tom's physical violence toward Agnes and his younger sisters emphasizes that his father and uncle's encouragement of his cruelty toward animals has real negative consequences for his treatment of other people. Victorian parents and educators were far more accepting of corporal punishment than people are today—indeed, Mr. Bloomfield likely punishes his children corporally. So the Bloomfields' refusal to let Agnes corporally punish Tom even when he hits her indicates not their tender-heartedness or progressiveness but rather their refusal to grant Agnes any real authority over the children, thus undermining her ability to teach them.



Tom will occasionally do his work so that he can go play, but Mary Ann often falls to the floor and lies there as if dead until mealtimes rather than do any schoolwork. If Agnes shakes her or pulls her hair or puts her in timeout, she shrieks until Mrs. Bloomfield comes and asks what on earth is going on. When Agnes explains that Mary Ann refuses to do her lessons, Mrs. Bloomfield—without force—tells her daughter to be a good girl and then, glaring at Agnes, says she hopes she won't hear any more screaming.

Again, Victorian parents and teachers accepted and practiced corporal punishment much more readily than people do today, so Victorian readers would likely not be shocked by Agnes pulling Mary Ann's hair, though modern readers may be. Mrs. Bloomfield wants Mary Ann to be quiet but gives Agnes no authority to discipline Mary Ann and blames Agnes for the child's noise—yet again indicating that Agnes's employers want her to do her job under impossible conditions.



When Fanny turns four and enters the school room, Agnes discovers that the little girl is a liar who spits in people's faces and “bellow[s]” when she doesn't get her way. Because Fanny has been quiet in front of Mr. Bloomfield and Mrs. Bloomfield in the past, they blame Agnes for the “bellowing” and insinuate that she has somehow taught Fanny bad behavior. Despite the parents' insinuations, Agnes resolves to continue in the job and improve the children's behavior—even when Mrs. Bloomfield tells Agnes her Christmas vacation will be shorter than she expected.

Fanny has just graduated from the nursery, where a nurse would have cared for her. Agnes would have had nothing to do with Fanny until she entered the schoolroom—yet the Bloomfields immediately blame Agnes for Fanny's behavior, which reveals their failure to take responsibility for their own children and desire to foist blame onto lower-status people in the household.



CHAPTER 4: THE GRANDMAMMA

Agnes notes to readers that she has enumerated the difficulties of educating Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny without support from Mr. Bloomfield and Mrs. Bloomfield's “more potent authority” specifically to enlighten parents and help other governesses.

At the novel's outset, Agnes implied that she was telling her story to teach readers a lesson. Here, she indicates at least one lesson she was trying to teach: to be successful teachers, governesses need support from their students' parents, because parents have “more potent authority”—that is, more power and influence—over their children's outcomes.



Back at the Bloomfields' after a happy Christmas at home, Agnes returns to work with resolve. One snowy day, Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny try to throw Agnes's work-bag into the fire and her desk out the window. As Agnes rescues her possessions, the children flee into the snow. Agnes is unsuccessfully ordering them back inside when Mr. Bloomfield comes by and yells at her. He orders the children back inside, tells her how obedient the children obviously are, and commands her to make the wet children "decent" again.

As Agnes follows the children inside, she overhears Mr. Bloomfield's mother—Mrs. Bloomfield Senior—asking the younger Mrs. Bloomfield whether Agnes is a "proper person." Up to this point, Mrs. Bloomfield Senior has been talkative with Agnes, even indirectly criticizing her daughter-in-law for not supporting Agnes's authority with the children more—criticisms Agnes has ignored, finding the way Mrs. Bloomfield Senior expresses them rather tasteless. Now Agnes realizes that Mrs. Bloomfield Senior is a back-biter.

The next time Mrs. Bloomfield Senior cozies up to Agnes, Agnes is stiff and chilly. Mrs. Bloomfield Senior becomes hostile until, one day, Agnes—out of mere politeness—asks after Mrs. Bloomfield Senior's health, at which point Mrs. Bloomfield Senior animatedly tells Agnes about all her illnesses and her "pious resignation" to them. Yet ultimately, because Agnes fails to flatter the woman, Mrs. Bloomfield Senior turns against her and begins telling Mr. Bloomfield that Agnes is a terrible governess.

Mr. Bloomfield starts surveilling Agnes. One day, in the spring, Tom, Mary Ann, and Fanny complete their lessons for once, and—kept indoors by rain—play with broken toys and, for some reason, eggshells. Because they aren't fighting, Agnes lets them play their odd game while she sews a dress for Mary Ann's doll. Then Mr. Bloomfield pops in, throws a fit about what effect the shells might have on the (plain, brown) carpet, and leaves the schoolroom slamming the door.

One day, when Agnes tells the children they must pick up after themselves before they'll get their next meal, Mary Ann and Fanny do it—but Tom, furious, hits his sisters, throws furniture, and scatters coal around. Agnes seizes Tom and sends Mary Ann to get Mrs. Bloomfield—only for Mrs. Bloomfield to order the maid to clean up and to give Tom his meal. Tom, while stuffing his face, gloats about his victory over Agnes. The only person who sympathizes with Agnes is the nurse, Betty, who has had to deal with similar problems—but she has been fired for corporally punishing the children.

Yet again, one of the Bloomfield parents is cruel to Agnes, a low-status employee, for failing to control the Bloomfield children—even though the Bloomfield parents have also refused to let Agnes discipline. Mr. Bloomfield's yelling at Agnes and his denial of his children's disobedience highlight the psychological discomfort and practical difficulty of Agnes's job.



Here readers learn that Agnes, in her attempts to educate the Bloomfield children, has to contend not only with the Bloomfield parents' casual cruelty toward employees but also with the extended Bloomfield family's attempts to undermine her. Mrs. Bloomfield Senior's question about whether Agnes is a "proper person" is clearly meant to cast doubt on Agnes's class status and thus her viability as a model for the young, middle-class Bloomfields' behavior.



Agnes and her loving family are all devoutly religious, so up to this point in the novel religion has had a positive connotation. Yet when Mrs. Bloomfield Senior praises her own "pious resignation" to her illness, the novel seems to suggest that cruel or shallow people use showy outward displays of religion to bolster their social status.



Though Agnes has succeeded in convincing the children to learn and not to fight, Mr. Bloomfield still explodes at her for letting the children get a plain carpet temporarily messy—an unfair, unnecessarily harsh criticism that shows both Mr. Bloomfield's failure to understand the difficulty of Agnes's job and his casual cruelty toward her.



Mrs. Bloomfield undermines Agnes's attempt to teach Tom responsibility and cleanliness by ordering the maid to clean up Tom's mess rather than insisting, with Agnes, that Tom clean up his own mess. This incident shows both how parents have the power to counteract teachers' lessons and how higher-class people foist their messes and responsibilities onto lower-class people (Tom's maid, not Tom, tidies his mess).



CHAPTER 5: THE UNCLE

Agnes dislikes visits from Mrs. Bloomfield's brother Uncle Robson, a strong, stupid, condescending man, because he has a bad effect on the children. He encourages Mary Ann's superficiality by praising her prettiness, which Agnes has tried to teach her is less important than her education and behavior. He also gives Tom alcohol and encourages the boy, through his own behavior and through words, to torture **animals**. Uncle Robson, for example, is very cruel to his hunting dogs and also takes the children "bird-nesting"—going to hunt down and kill baby birds.

One day, Tom runs into the garden holding a nest of baby **birds** and announces his plan to amuse himself by killing them. Agnes, standing by, tells him she won't let him torture the animals: he must kill them quickly or return them so their parents can feed them. If he doesn't, she'll kill them herself. Tom, laughing, tells her she won't dare because Mr. Bloomfield, Mrs. Bloomfield, and Uncle Robson would be angry at her. Agnes says she'll do what she believes to be right.

Agnes finds a large stone. Then she asks what Tom will do with the **birds**. He describes how he will torture them, so Agnes drops the stone onto the nest, killing them. Tom, furious, sees his Uncle Robson walking up (and about to kick his dog). He runs to Uncle Robson and complains violently about Agnes, which makes Uncle Robson laugh. Uncle Robson praises Tom's refusal of "petticoat government" and promises to get him another bird's nest. Agnes tells Uncle Robson that if he does, she'll kill those too. He glares at her. When she doesn't cringe, he stomps into the house.

Tom runs to complain to Mrs. Bloomfield. The next time Agnes sees her, she coldly professes her regret that Agnes "interfere[d] with Master Bloomfield's amusements." Agnes—quoting the Bible—tries to convince Mrs. Bloomfield that people have no right to torture **animals** and acting mercifully toward animals teaches virtue; Mrs. Bloomfield replies that animals "were all created" for people's "convenience" and that Agnes was merciless in thwarting Tom's enjoyment. Their talk ends.

This passage reinforces what readers have already guessed: Tom has learned his cruel behavior toward helpless animals and social "inferiors" from his older male relatives, especially his father and his uncle. Mary Ann has learned to value herself for her looks rather than her accomplishments in the same way. Because Agnes is lower status in the Bloomfield household than Uncle Robson, the children are more likely to listen to him than to her, so his bad influence easily undoes whatever she has been able to teach the children.



Agnes, as a young woman and an employee, has less social power than her employers the Bloomfields or Uncle Robson—but that doesn't make her a pushover. Implicitly, she insists on doing what is right—preventing the torture of animals—not only out of moral sensibility and self-respect but also out of a desire to model moral behavior to Tom.



The phrase "petticoat government" refers to female authority, as petticoats (underskirts) were clothes worn by Victorian women, not men. The association in this scene between young Tom's animal cruelty and his disrespect for women implies that men who harm helpless animals, like Tom and Uncle Robson, may also be likely to despise and hurt women—who in the Victorian era had much less power than men.



When Agnes—with sincere religious feeling and quotations from the Bible—tries to convince Mrs. Bloomfield that how Tom treats helpless animals will have ramifications for his moral character, Mrs. Bloomfield uses a shallow, self-serving interpretation of Christian scripture to claim that God created animals merely for people's "convenience." Thus, Mrs. Bloomfield thwarts Agnes's attempts to teach Tom better morals, insists on a destructive power hierarchy in the household, and uses insincere religion as a tool to justify her son's cruel behavior.



Agnes dislikes it when anyone visits the Bloomfields, not just when Mrs. Bloomfield Senior and Uncle Robson visit, because Mrs. Bloomfield expects her to keep Tom and Mary Ann away from the guests but never helps her do so. Then, one day, Mrs. Bloomfield summons her and fires her on the grounds that—though they have no complaints about Agnes’s morals or behavior—the children aren’t improving, which she believes is because Agnes doesn’t discipline the children firmly enough or try hard enough. Agnes is devastated to be sent home a failure at her first job, but she resolves to try again—hopefully with a better family.

The Bloomfields have forbidden Agnes from disciplining their children and have consistently undermined all Agnes’s attempts to improve the children’s behavior—yet they blame the children’s failure to improve on Agnes, not themselves. This stunning misdiagnosis of the problem shows the Bloomfields’ failure to understand their power as parents—and, more generally, the tendency of higher-status people to scapegoat lower-status people when things go wrong.



CHAPTER 6: THE PARSONAGE AGAIN

Agnes lives at home for several months, happy to be among her loved ones. Yet as her sick father Richard Grey worries incessantly about what will happen to her, Mary, and their mother when he dies, Agnes takes her mother aside and says she would like to find another governess position to help the family finances. When she says that not everyone could be like the Bloomfields, her mother warns her that some might be worse—but Agnes persists. As the families advertising for governesses tend to make stringent demands while offering low pay, Agnes’s mother suggests that Agnes put out her own advertisement listing her thorough educational accomplishments (which include German, French, and Latin).

That families advertising for governesses want a great deal from their employees while offering small salaries speaks to the unenviable position of women in the Victorian era: because women had low social status and limited job opportunities, prospective employers of female educators like governesses had substantial power over them. This is true even for a highly educated young woman like Agnes, who knows three foreign languages in addition to her other accomplishments.



Two families reply to Agnes’s advertisement, and one agrees to the salary she demanded. Agnes is worried that that family’s children are too old for her to teach, but her mother encourages her to be bold and self-confident. Agnes takes the position and plans to travel to Horton Lodge 70 miles away to become the Murrays’ governess. As Agnes has never traveled more than 20 miles from home, this distance seems like an adventure to her. Further, as Mr. Murray is higher-class than Mr. Bloomfield, she hopes he will have better manners and treat her more like a social equal. She is also excited at her higher salary, of which she anticipates saving a large fraction to help her family.

Agnes hopes that Mr. Murray will treat her better than Mr. Bloomfield, indicating that she still believes higher social class correlates with better manners and more kindness. Yet given how the Bloomfields saw their higher social status relative to Agnes as an excuse to treat her badly, readers may doubt that an even greater gap between Mr. Murray’s social status and Agnes’s will lead him to behave kindly toward her.



CHAPTER 7: HORTON LODGE

Agnes sets out for Horton Lodge on January 31. The journey is so long and snowy that she arrives past dark. In the schoolroom she meets her new students, two teenage girls and two boys. The younger girl, a tomboyish 14-year-old named Matilda, shows her to her room. No one brings up Agnes's luggage, however, until she goes out, finds a servant, and asks after it. When Agnes wakes up the next morning, she goes down to the schoolroom reminding herself to call her students "Miss" and "Master" rather than by their given names, as Mr. Bloomfield and Mrs. Bloomfield had taught her they wanted—despite Agnes's feeling that this is an "absurd" piece of formality that smothers friendliness.

Agnes resolves not to bore her audience with a minute accounting of how she came to understand the Murrays. Instead, she summarizes the impressions she gained of them over her first year of employment. Agnes almost never sees Mr. Murray, though she hears he is an avid hunter and skilled farmer; occasionally, she hears him cursing at servants.

Mrs. Murray is an attractive 40-year-old who likes fashion, parties, and sleeping late; she wants Agnes to make her daughters "superficially attractive and showily accomplished" and her sons good at Latin—without her children needing to make much effort. She advises Agnes to come and get her if any of the children need a stern talking-to, as it wouldn't be "proper" for Agnes to talk to them that way herself. Naïve Agnes is shocked at how concerned Mrs. Murray is for her children's absolute comfort—while never talking about Agnes's comfort.

Rosalie Murray, who's 16 when Agnes arrives, is an unusually pretty girl with brown hair and blue eyes. Though cold to Agnes at first, she becomes as fond of Agnes as she can be of a family employee—for she's very status conscious. Agnes suspects that Rosalie admires Agnes more than Rosalie herself realizes, for Agnes's honesty, dutifulness, and open praise of upright behavior. According to Agnes, Rosalie's admiration shows not Agnes's goodness so much as the Murrays' sad lack of it.

Sadly, Agnes has learned from the Bloomfields that employers of governesses (that is, rich parents) want governesses to treat their students like little employers themselves rather than children in need of guidance and discipline. Agnes believes that such behavior is "absurd," but she is willing to engage in it to secure a job and support her family, showing that she is pragmatic as well as principled.



Almost the first thing readers learn about Mr. Murray is that he verbally abuses his servants—suggesting that Agnes was wrong to hope he would treat his employees better than Mr. Bloomfield did simply because he is higher-class than Mr. Bloomfield.



The negatively connoted words "superficially" and "showily" indicate that Agnes does not share Mrs. Murray's implied value system, in which women should achieve economic security and social status through marriage to the richest, highest-born man available. Yet Agnes's own precarious position as a female employee makes clear that advantageous marriages are one of the few ways that middle-class Victorian women can find security. Meanwhile, Mrs. Murray's claim that it wouldn't be "proper" for Agnes to chastise the Murray children suggests that the Murrays, like the Bloomfields, are more interested in preserving their households' economic and social hierarchy than helping Agnes be an effective teacher.



This passage indicates that Rosalie can only care so much about a family employee because status matters so much to her—emphasizing that status hierarchies tend to make higher-status people indifferent, callous, or even cruel toward lower-status people.



Rosalie's lack of principle pains Agnes in part because Agnes quite likes the girl: she's good-tempered, high-spirited, and talented at music and foreign languages. Yet her family has never taught her sound moral principles or encouraged her to apply herself, whereas they have encouraged her to abuse power over servants and pursue her own whims. Thus, Rosalie is shallow, undisciplined, and vain. She's only interested in learning things that make her attractive to young men, such as singing or French.

Rosalie has learned to be vain and lazy from her parents despite her naturally occurring virtues, showing the importance of the family environment to children's moral formation. That her family has actively encouraged her to mistreat servants, meanwhile, indicates that the Murrys are more interested in reinforcing social hierarchies than they are in modeling moral behavior to their children. Finally, Rosalie's sole ambition is to be attractive, suggesting how limited opportunities for Victorian girls and women limit their dreams, too.



Matilda, Rosalie's tomboyish younger sister, is rather large and awkward—but doesn't care that she isn't pretty like Rosalie. Nor does she care about education or "accomplishments." When Agnes attempts to teach her anything, she develops a foul mood and tends to blame Agnes for her own mistakes. Yet as soon as she is riding **horses** or playing with dogs or her siblings, she's good-tempered again. Mrs. Murray tries to tell Agnes to flatter Matilda into learning, so that Matilda need make no effort—but Agnes, frustrated, thinks that all learning requires effort. Matilda has also learned to swear from Mr. Murray and from the male servants, which shocks Agnes.

Since kindness toward animals correlates with moral goodness throughout the novel, Matilda's fondness for horses and dogs may indicate that she, like her sister Rosalie, has some innate virtues. Yet where Mrs. Murray's shallowness has led Rosalie astray, Agnes clearly thinks that Mr. Murray's coarseness has led Matilda astray, leading Matilda to imitate her father's bad "masculine" behavior the way Rosalie imitates her mother's bad "feminine" behavior.



11-year-old John Murray has a good enough natural character but, having been poorly brought up, is overly energetic and "unteachable." Luckily for Agnes, the Murrys send him to boarding school after a year. 10-year-old Charles, Mrs. Murray's pet, is a weak and nasty little liar; as Mrs. Murray insists that Agnes correct all his mistakes at once rather than let him figure out how to fix them. And as Charles tells on her if she tries to make him work harder, he learns virtually nothing in two years, after which he too is sent to boarding school.

Agnes's brief accounts of John and Charles Murray make clear yet again how parents can spoil their children and render them "unteachable" despite educators' best efforts—especially if parents are powerful employers who can dictate to educators how to teach.



The Murrys' house, Horton Lodge, is two miles from church, so the Murrys often take the carriage. If the children decide to walk, Agnes can walk with them—otherwise she ends up crushed in the worst seat in the carriage, which makes her feel sick all through church services. Once, Matilda exclaims how strange it is that the carriage makes Agnes sick when it doesn't make her sick, and Rosalie exclaims about the "nasty, horrid place" Miss Grey chooses to sit in.

Matilda and Rosalie's comments show their thoughtlessness and lack of empathy for their family employee. Matilda fails to make the connection between Agnes's sickness and the uncomfortable position the family carriage forces Agnes into, while Rosalie recognizes that the position is "nasty" and "horrid" but doesn't seem to realize that Agnes ends up there due to the Murrys' actions rather than her own preferences.



The Murray children keep irregular hours and often bother Agnes to get their lessons over with at strange times. The servants, observing their employers' careless behavior toward Agnes, learn to treat her rather contemptuously. Yet—especially after the boys leave for school—Agnes feels that she is able to make small improvements with Matilda and Rosalie, who think she is a strange and sometimes annoying do-gooder but nevertheless entertaining in her way.

The servants' learned contempt toward Agnes shows how disrespectfully the Murrays treat Agnes—illustrating the strange, alienated position of the educated and middle-class yet low-status governess in the Victorian household. Yet the minor improvements that Agnes makes with the Murray girls suggest that Agnes isn't entirely powerless in the household.



CHAPTER 8: THE 'COMING OUT'

After Rosalie turns 18, she plans to be introduced to society with an enormous ball on January 3. The Murrays will invite all the aristocrats, gentlemen, and ladies in their village and the surrounding countryside. The December beforehand, while Agnes is reading a letter from her sister Mary, Rosalie interrupts her. Rosalie tells Agnes to put away her “stupid” letter and says that Agnes has to delay leaving on holiday until after the ball. When Agnes points out that she won't attend the ball, Rosalie says that Agnes will be able to see her in her ball dress and “be ready to worship her.”

Rosalie calls Agnes's letter “stupid” without knowing its contents and asks Agnes to postpone her holiday in order to “worship” Rosalie in her new dress. Rosalie's behavior shows her egotism and casual disrespect for Agnes as a low-status employee—yet, at the same time, her desire that Agnes witness her triumph implies her unconscious respect and liking for Agnes.



Agnes tells Rosalie that she wants to see her family—and that her sister, Mary, is getting married in January. When Rosalie asks why Agnes didn't mention this news earlier, Agnes says she just learned about it in her “stupid” letter. Rosalie asks whether Mary's fiancé is young, good-looking, and wealthy, to which Agnes replies that he's the vicar of a nearby parish—middle-aged, “only decent,” and “only comfortable.” When Rosalie expresses utter horror, Agnes points out that Rosalie never asked whether the man was good, kind, or intelligent—and he's all those things. Rosalie is still horrified by the vision of Mary's plain clothes and visits to “poor parishioners.”

In this scene, Agnes gently and indirectly tries to educate Rosalie. By revealing that Agnes learned of her sister's marriage in the letter Rosalie called “stupid,” Agnes suggests to Rosalie that Agnes's correspondence may be important even if Agnes is a low-status governess. By describing her sister's fiancé as “only decent” and “only comfortable” yet good, kind, and intelligent, she implicitly corrects Rosalie's shallow views of what makes a good husband. Yet Rosalie, shaped by the values of her status-seeking family, largely fails to take Agnes's point.



CHAPTER 9: THE BALL

When Agnes reenters the schoolroom after her Christmas vacation, Rosalie demands to tell her about the ball. She counts for Agnes all the aristocrats who attended her ball, gloats about how much more beautiful she was than the other women, and rejoices at her many “conquests.” Agnes asks why she would need more than one, suggesting that even one would be too much unless Rosalie liked the man back.

Mrs. Murray has taught Rosalie to value her attractiveness to the exclusion of her other qualities and to take ensnaring men's hearts as her chief ambition. Agnes, formed by a very different early family education, finds Rosalie's celebration of her “conquests” baffling.



Rosalie pooh-poohs this idea and begins describing her admirers, including a married nobleman (to Agnes's horror) and Sir Thomas Ashby. Evidently Sir Ashby, though wealthy, is an "ugly beast," but Mrs. Murray has told Rosalie that she will see past this fact soon enough. Rosalie also mentions Harry Meltham (whom she likes but does not see as a serious prospect because he's a younger son) and the village rector Mr. Hatfield. As an aside, Rosalie mentions that Mr. Hatfield has a new curate. When Agnes asks about him, Rosalie says the man, Mr. Weston, is an "ugly, stupid blockhead" and refuses to talk of him further.

Though bored, Agnes asks Rosalie which admirer she prefers. Rosalie claims to scorn them all. Though Harry Meltham is the most entertaining and Mr. Hatfield the most intelligent, she guesses she'll end up accepting Sir Ashby, the "wickedest." Agnes asks why Rosalie would do that if Sir Ashby is a bad man whom she dislikes. Rosalie explains that if she has to marry, she'd like to be "Lady Ashby of Ashby Park," but she would prefer to be young, single, and flirtatious forever—and she hopes to remain so until the last possible moment, after having broken thousands of hearts. Agnes suggests that if these are Rosalie's ideas about marriage, she ought not marry at all.

Mrs. Murray encourages Rosalie to overlook that Sir Thomas Ashby is an "ugly beast," a description that implicates both his physical appearance ("ugly") and his manners ("beast"). Sir Thomas Ashby, unlike Rosalie's other single admirers, has a title—so Mrs. Murray's implicit instruction to Rosalie to ignore his physical and behavioral ugliness indicates that Mrs. Murray wants Rosalie to marry the highest-ranking man she can regardless of his personal attractions. This desire is another example of Mrs. Murray foisting questionable ambitions and values onto her daughter.



Rosalie has learned—likely from Mrs. Murray—to value status over moral goodness. Ergo, she is willing to marry her "wickedest" suitor to gain a title and an estate, Ashby Park. Yet Rosalie is ambitious in her way: she would prefer exercising her talents and powers to getting married. Unfortunately, due to her poor moral education and the limited opportunities available to Victorian women, her talents and powers all lie in the arena of flirtation—which, as Agnes's commentary suggests, doesn't set Rosalie up for a happy marriage when she does accept a suitor.



CHAPTER 10: THE CHURCH

On their way back from church one Sunday, Rosalie asks what Agnes thinks of the new curate Mr. Weston. When Agnes points out that she hasn't heard Mr. Weston preach yet, Rosalie asks impatiently whether Agnes thinks he's ugly. Agnes says no—the only thing that struck her about her was his reading of the Bible and of prayers, which struck her as intelligent and heartfelt. Rosalie claims that Mr. Weston is only good for church services and expresses how glad she is that she need not depend on him for entertainment.

Then Rosalie asks whether Agnes noticed how Mr. Hatfield hurried out of church to help the Murrays into their carriage. Agnes says yes—thinking to herself that it was undignified behavior from a priest and resenting that he nearly shut the carriage door in her face after helping the Murrays in. In fact, Mr. Hatfield, Harry Meltham, and the Murrays' other visitors never acknowledge Agnes.

Rosalie has learned from Mrs. Murray to judge people by their appearances and so believes that Agnes can judge Mr. Weston without having heard him speak. Agnes, who has had a very different education from Rosalie's due to her poor yet well-educated religious family, judges Mr. Weston solely by what she can glean from his manner of reading.



Mr. Hatfield, though a priest, is as callous to Agnes as the Murrays' other high-status acquaintances, all of whom treat her like furniture. Mr. Hatfield's callousness suggests that his religious beliefs may be warped, insincere, or hypocritically practiced.



Rosalie decides to attend a second church service in the afternoon so that she can see Harry Meltham again and so that Agnes can hear Mr. Weston preach. In church, Agnes is struck by the pleasant contrast of Mr. Weston's strong, simple, truthful homily with Mr. Hatfield's sermons. Mr. Hatfield uses his sermons as opportunities to flash around his expensive rings, criticize all forms of individual religious thought, and argue that poor people ought to practice "deferential obedience" to rich people—when he is not threatening people with hell. Agnes thinks he is one of those people who tasks others with piety, humility, and goodness without practicing it himself.

After church, Harry Meltham hands Rosalie and Matilda into their carriage—but not Agnes, though he doesn't shut the door in her face either. When Rosalie asks what Agnes thinks of "him," Agnes briefly thinks she's asking about Mr. Weston and replies, "No harm still." Rosalie, shocked, says he's ever so much better now—and Agnes realizes that she's talking about Harry Meltham. Matilda announces that Harry Meltham would be a "jolly companion" and argues that he likes her as much as he likes Rosalie. When Rosalie sniffs that only old men and younger sons could tolerate Matilda's manners, Matilda snaps back that she isn't "grubbing after money" like Rosalie and Mrs. Murray. Luckily, the end of the carriage ride ends the sisters' fight.

Here Agnes makes explicit her judgment—which readers have no reason to disbelieve—that Mr. Hatfield is a religious hypocrite who distorts Christian doctrine to justify social hierarchies (e.g. "deferential obedience" of poor people to rich people) and holds other people to higher standards that he holds himself. Mr. Hatfield's cruelty toward the poor shows that an outward profession of religion doesn't necessarily correlate with increased kindness toward lower-status people.



Harry Meltham's failure to extend any politeness to Agnes emphasizes that all the Murrays' acquaintances think of Agnes as lower status and thus not worth treating well because she's an employee. Agnes and Rosalie's different understandings of "him" shows which men they understand to be worth thinking about—and may hint that Agnes feels some nascent attraction for Mr. Weston. Meanwhile, Matilda's awareness that her mother and Rosalie are "grubbing after money"—i.e. that they both want Rosalie to marry the richest man possible—shows how overt the Murrays' materialistic considerations are.



CHAPTER 11: THE COTTAGERS

Agnes now teaches Rosalie only German and drawing; Matilda is her sole full-time student. With her free time, Agnes writes letters, studies, and takes walks. As she has been introduced to poor cottagers on the Murrays' lands by going on charitable visits to them with Rosalie and Matilda—who mock the cottagers they're supposed to be helping, to Agnes's dismay—Agnes has begun visiting several cottagers by herself.

One February day, Agnes decides to go read to a cottager, a widow named Nancy Brown, who is suffering from an eye inflammation and so cannot currently read herself. Agnes finds Nancy knitting at home with her **cat** and asks how she is. Nancy says that she's feeling cheerful though her eyes are not improved—which is good news, as Nancy also suffers from "religious melancholy." After Agnes has read a Gospel passage to Nancy, Nancy unexpectedly asks for Agnes's opinion of Mr. Weston. When Agnes says that he preaches well, Nancy adds that he also speaks well—he visits the poor villagers often and is far more welcome than Mr. Hatfield.

Rosalie and Matilda make fun of the poor people they are supposed to be helping, a clear indication that they see nothing wrong with casual cruelty toward lower-status people. By contrast, Agnes genuinely wants to help those less fortunate than herself.



As kindness toward animals correlates with moral goodness throughout the novel, Nancy Brown's cat may symbolize that Nancy is a morally upright person whose opinion ought to be taken seriously. "Melancholy" can simply mean "sadness," but it was also a common term in the pre-psychiatry era for a cluster of symptoms people would now associate with clinical depression. Nancy's abrupt revelation that Mr. Weston is kinder to and more beloved by the village poor than Mr. Hatfield, meanwhile, confirms Agnes's good first impression of Mr. Weston and negative judgment on Mr. Hatfield.



Nancy explains to Agnes that Mr. Hatfield is always criticizing the poor villagers he visits. After Nancy became terrified that she couldn't love other people or God as the Bible instructs, she asked Mr. Hatfield to visit. He listened to her worries scornfully and told her she needed to attend church rather than reading her Bible alone. When she explained that her rheumatism made it hard to walk to church in winter, he accused her of laziness and told her that if she couldn't get comfort from church, she was likely damned. Then he asked after the Miss Murrays. When Nancy said she'd seen Rosalie nearby, Mr. Hatfield hurried out happily—kicking Nancy's **cat** on the way.

Nancy apologizes to Agnes for talking so much, but Agnes urges her to continue. Nancy explains that after Mr. Hatfield's visit, she did try to attend church—and the cold walks caused her eye inflammation, while the services didn't ease her melancholy. One Sunday, she approached Mr. Hatfield to discuss her unhappy fears again, and he told her not to bother him. When the new curate Mr. Weston asked who she was, she overheard Mr. Hatfield call her an "old fool." Yet the next day, Mr. Weston visited her, petted her **cat** kindly, asked for her story, and listened respectfully.

Nancy explains that Mr. Weston told her that Mr. Hatfield's advice to attend church was correct but incomplete: church is an aid to following the two great commandments, loving God and loving one's neighbor. And doing so becomes easier when you consider God as the source of all goodness and your "best friend" and your neighbors as beloved of God. Moreover, if you can't feel love for your neighbors, you should still try to do good for them, and you may slowly come to love them. After Mr. Weston left, one of Nancy's neighbors came over and almost started a fight with her, but Nancy recalled Mr. Weston's words, responded kindly, and defused the situation.

Agnes asks whether Mr. Weston has visited Nancy since then. Nancy says that he has, though he is busy visiting many villagers. His excellent sermons make her very happy and inspire her to be kind to her neighbors. When Agnes at last leaves Nancy's cottage, she's feeling very happy too.

In the novel, people's cruelty toward animals both symbolizes and predicts their cruelty toward lower-status humans. When Mr. Hatfield kicks Nancy's cat, then, it functions as a condemnation of his attitude toward Nancy and the poor villagers in general. Rather than trying to help Nancy with her depression and religious doubts, Mr. Hatfield simply blames her for them—showing the shallowness of his nominal Christianity.



Whereas Mr. Hatfield kicked Nancy's cat, Mr. Weston treats it gently. Given the association between kindness to animals and kindness to vulnerable humans throughout the novel, Mr. Weston's good treatment of Nancy's cat clearly indicates that he is more sincerely religious and a better shepherd of the village parishioners than Mr. Hatfield.



Mr. Hatfield simply ordered Nancy to attend church, the way a superior orders around an inferior. By contrast, Mr. Weston gave Nancy a rationale for attending church—the way one equal reasons with another—and then gave her sound advice based on their shared Christian beliefs. Mr. Weston's kindness, gentleness, and helpfulness toward Nancy show his religious sincerity in contrast with Mr. Hatfield's cruelty and hypocrisy.



Nancy's revelation that Mr. Weston visits many of the poor villagers emphasizes again his goodness and religious sincerity. Meanwhile, Agnes's happiness at the revelation may come from religious feeling—or may indicate that Agnes has a deepening crush on Mr. Weston and is glad to hear good things about him.



Another day, Agnes goes to read to a poor cottager dying of tuberculosis, and both he and his wife praise Mr. Weston, who visits them often. They consider Mr. Weston immensely superior to Mr. Hatfield, who visits hastily and is always criticizing the sick man's wife. Mr. Weston even sent them extra coal when he noticed their cottage was cold and their fire small. At this point, Agnes remembers "with a species of exultation" that Rosalie has harshly criticized Mr. Weston for not dressing as flashily as Mr. Hatfield.

Agnes goes home very happy: prior to this point, she has had nothing both new and improving to think about and has worried that socializing only with Rosalie and Matilda was likely to make her a worse person as their flaws rubbed off on her. Mr. Weston offers her a new model of human behavior that is morally improving to think about. She begins to look forward to Sundays as a time she can listen to Mr. Weston and contemplate his virtues.

The dying cottager's contrasting accounts of Mr. Hatfield and Mr. Weston makes clear yet again that Mr. Hatfield is a cruel, status-conscious religious hypocrite, whereas Mr. Weston is a good and religiously sincere man. Agnes's "exultation" at remembering Rosalie's criticisms of Mr. Weston may hint that Agnes is falling in love with Mr. Weston—and doesn't want flirtatious Rosalie to like him too.



The novel has already illustrated how the Bloomfield and Murray parents have taught their children bad behavior and values—not necessarily explicitly, but through the example of their own behavior. Now Agnes is suggesting that this kind of education doesn't only occur between parents and children: a person's friends, acquaintances, and even employers "teach" them how to behave by their example. Agnes is worried about learning the lessons that the superficial Murrays have to teach, so she latches on to Mr. Weston as a better example and "teacher."



CHAPTER 12: THE SHOWER

In mid-March, when Agnes has a free moment while Matilda is going for a ride and Rosalie is socially busy, she decides to visit Nancy again. When she arrives, Nancy is deeply anxious about her **cat**, which has disappeared and which she fears gamekeepers will kill. After Agnes reads to Nancy and helps her with some sewing, Mr. Weston enters carrying the cat. He sees Agnes, bows to her, and gives the cat to Nancy, saying that he saved it from Mr. Murray's gamekeeper. Nancy thanks him ecstatically.

When Agnes prepares to leave, Nancy tells her to stay until the rain that has started stops again. Meanwhile, Mr. Weston announces his intention to go, noting that "someone else" has been reading to Nancy. Nancy announces that Agnes has been sewing for her too. As Mr. Weston prepares to leave, he half-jokingly asks Agnes to make amends for him with Mr. Murray, who directed "ungentlemanly language" at him when he saved the **cat** that had been stalking his rabbits. Agnes tells Mr. Weston that unfortunately, she can't help—she rarely sees Mr. Murray. Mr. Weston says goodbye and leaves. A while later, Agnes leaves too. Back at Horton Lodge, Matilda complains that the rain cut her ride short, but Agnes wasn't at home to make her tea.

Mr. Weston is not only kind to Nancy's cat when he visits Nancy—he goes out of his way to save her cat when it disappears. Yet again, the novel is linking kindness toward animals with kindness toward other humans, as well as setting up Mr. Weston as an exemplar of human goodness and religious sincerity.



When Mr. Weston mentions that "someone else" has been reading to Nancy, he clearly means Agnes—he has noticed that she engages in charitable acts toward the poor villagers just like he does. Moreover, he attempts to engage her directly in conversation before leaving Nancy's cottage in a way that reveals he knows she's Mr. Murray's employee. These details may suggest that Mr. Murray has been noticing Agnes with approval, just as she has been noticing him.



CHAPTER 13: THE PRIMROSES

Rosalie has started going to church twice on Sundays to give her admirers more opportunity to admire her, both in church and on the walk home—she has stopped taking the carriage to allow her acquaintances to accompany her. Agnes walks with Rosalie and Matilda or takes the carriage depending on the girls' whims. Agnes dislikes walking with Rosalie and Matilda because their acquaintances always ignore her, and she doesn't want either to walk with them in silence or walk far behind and so seem to “acknowledge [her] own inferiority.”

One Sunday, Agnes hangs back from the walking party to enjoy the spring weather when she sees some **primroses** blooming high up in an oak's roots on a bank. Agnes tries to pick them, but she can't reach. To her surprise, Mr. Weston comes up behind her, asks to help, and gets the primroses for her. Agnes thanks him, feeling intensely grateful for his considerateness, yet she also feels rather awkward. As they resume walking, Mr. Weston notes that Rosalie and Matilda have left Agnes alone and then asks Agnes about her favorite flowers. She explains that her favorites are those she associates with her home: primroses, bluebells, and heath-flowers.

Mr. Weston suggests that Agnes must derive comfort from having a home even if it's far away. Warmly, Agnes says she couldn't live without it. Mr. Weston replies that she could: people's hearts are tougher than they think. Less than a year ago, he “lost the last and dearest of [his] early friends” and has no home anymore, but he still feels some hope for life, even if he envies those with homes. Agnes suggests that he may still have a happy future, and he answers that he already has “the power and the will to be useful,” which makes him happy. Then Mr. Weston parts with Agnes to approach a farmhouse.

As Agnes walks, she thinks about Mr. Weston's words: having heard that his mother died before he came to the village, she infers that his mother is the “last and dearest” friend he lost. She feels deep, emotional sympathy for his grief and admires his hard work despite it; she also predicts that he can still find a new home and a life partner. While praying that he finds a worthy partner, she thinks “how delightful it would be to—” but then she cuts herself off, thinking that no one is bound to share all their thoughts with other people.

Agnes is neither stupid nor emotionally hardened: she knows that the Murrays and their acquaintances are slighting her due to her lower social status, and it pains her. Yet she is also proud enough not to want to “acknowledge [her] own inferiority”—because she believes herself inferior to the Murrays only economically, not in terms of real values such as goodness.



Flowers are often associated with romantic love in literature and culture. In this passage, Agnes associates flowers with her loving home—so that when Mr. Weston, on whom she has an unstated crush, gives her flowers, the novel may be hinting that he could provide a new loving home for her through marriage. Mr. Weston notices that Rosalie and Matilda are impolitely shunning Agnes, showing his concern for Agnes and his implicit judgment on the Murray girls' status-consciousness.



Though it is not immediately obvious who Mr. Weston means by “the last and dearest of [his] early friends,” he has clearly suffered intense grief. Agnes's suggestion that Mr. Weston can still have a happy future may betray her subconscious desire to be part of that happy future—perhaps eventually as his wife—while Mr. Weston's claim that “the power and the will to be useful” make him happy reminds readers of his charitable works and religious sincerity.



Agnes is contemplating Mr. Weston finding a worthy wife when she thinks “how delightful it would be to—” and then cuts herself off. Her self-interruption suggests that she may want to marry Mr. Weston but is somewhat embarrassed to admit it.



When Agnes returns to Horton Lodge, Rosalie makes insinuations about why Agnes walks behind the group and why Agnes defends Mr. Weston when Rosalie criticizes him. Agnes tells Rosalie not to be silly. When Rosalie and Matilda keep teasing Agnes, she exclaims that this was only the second time she'd talked to him. When the girls ask where Agnes talked to him first, Agnes says at Nancy's cottage—and Rosalie laughingly accuses Agnes of visiting Nancy to rendezvous with him. Yet the girls quickly move on from teasing Agnes, who goes up to her room and prays to God for "another's welfare" along with her own. She also presses one of the **primroses** into her Bible.

Readers may suspect that Rosalie has guessed correctly when she insinuates that Agnes has a crush on Mr. Weston. Yet Rosalie is incorrect in claiming that Agnes was visiting Nancy Brown to run into Mr. Weston, as Agnes did not know that Mr. Weston was an acquaintance of Nancy's when she began visiting Nancy. Rather, Agnes visits Nancy out of real friendship and religious charity. Rosalie's cynicism about Agnes's motives contrasts with Agnes's religious sincerity and highlights a difference in the two young women's approach to romantic matters. When Agnes presses a primrose that Mr. Weston gave her into her Bible, meanwhile, it underscores the role that religious admiration has played in forming Agnes's crush on Mr. Weston while emphasizing that the primroses symbolize romantic love.



CHAPTER 14: THE RECTOR

The next day after Matilda has finished her lessons, Agnes is painting a watercolor in the schoolroom at Rosalie's request while Rosalie goes for a walk with a novel. Lying at Agnes's feet is **Snap**, a terrier. Matilda planned to raise Snap but neglected him. Agnes cared for him, and now he adores Agnes—much to Matilda's spiteful annoyance.

Throughout the novel, kindness toward animals has both predicted and symbolized kindness toward vulnerable humans. As such, Matilda's enthusiasm for dogs and horses seemed to indicate some innate goodness in her despite the poor education she has received from Mr. Murray. Yet Matilda's neglect of Snap, a helpless and vulnerable puppy, suggests that while Matilda may not be actively cruel like Tom Bloomfield, she is careless of the needs of those dependent on her. This carelessness contrasts with Agnes's thoughtfulness and care for Snap.



Mrs. Murray rushes into the schoolroom and asks why Agnes isn't out walking with Rosalie and Matilda. When Agnes points out that Matilda is with the other **dogs** and Rosalie is reading, Mrs. Murray accuses Agnes of being insufficiently entertaining to keep Matilda from unladylike pursuits and company. Then Mrs. Murray asks why Rosalie is spending so much time by herself. When Agnes repeats that Rosalie is reading, Mrs. Murray asks why she can't do it on the Murray property. She recounts how Mr. Hatfield finds Rosalie reading in "the fields and lanes" so often. Then she orders Agnes to go remind Rosalie that she shouldn't allow admirers to approach her familiarly while alone.

Mrs. Murray has ordered Agnes not to give Rosalie or Matilda stern talking-tos—yet she blames Agnes for the tomboyish behavior that Matilda learned from Mr. Murray before Agnes even arrived in the Murrays' household. Like the Bloomfields, Mrs. Murray denies Agnes authority over her students and then makes unreasonable demands on her as a teacher. Given Mrs. Murray's apparent desire that Rosalie marry her richest and highest-status suitor, Sir Thomas Ashby, readers may wonder whether Mrs. Murray is worried about Mr. Hatfield courting Rosalie due to propriety or due to his lesser wealth and social status.



Agnes exits the house and spots Rosalie walking with Mr. Hatfield in a field just beyond the Murrays' property. Rosalie is holding a book in one hand and some **myrtle** in the other, looking coquettishly at her admirer. The terrier **Snap**, running ahead of Agnes, bites Rosalie's dress, and Mr. Hatfield hits Snap with his cane. As Agnes is comforting the dog, Mr. Hatfield asks Rosalie when they'll see each other again. When Rosalie says church—unless he happens to come by again exactly when she's out walking—he asks for her myrtle as a consolation. After playfully refusing, Rosalie gives it to him. He leaves.

Myrtle is a flowering plant. Rosalie's use of flowers to flirt with Mr. Hatfield, making him beg her for them, contrasts with Agnes's attempts to get flowers by herself—only to be aided by the courteous Mr. Weston. The two interactions involving flowers create an implicit contrast between Rosalie's and Agnes's attitudes toward romance: Rosalie sees romance as a game she wants to win against male opponents, whereas Agnes doesn't seek to play romantic games but is pleased to receive respectful romantic overtures from a good man. When Mr. Hatfield hits Snap with his cane, readers are reminded of his earlier cruelty toward Nancy Brown's cat and his cruelty toward the poor, low-status cottagers. His cruelty and status-consciousness call into question his motives for courting Rosalie: does he love her, or is he seeking her family's money and status?



Rosalie exclaims how glad she is that Agnes drove away Mr. Hatfield, whom she thought would never leave and whom she didn't want Mr. Murray to see. Agnes asks whether Mr. Hatfield was bothering her for long. Rosalie says no, but he often passes by the property on various pretexts and engages her in conversation. Agnes explains that Mrs. Murray thinks Rosalie shouldn't walk off the property without a chaperone, and Rosalie, miffed, says that she's in no danger—she will never fall in love. At most, she'll have a "preference," but only for someone richer than Mr. Hatfield, entertaining though he is.

Rosalie's cynical attitude toward love and marriage makes a certain amount of sense given her family education and social position: her mother has raised her to believe that, as an upper-middle-class Victorian woman, she should seek to make the most economically and socially advantageous marriage possible—a goal that does not leave room for genuine, passionate love but at most for a "preference."



Rosalie laments that Mrs. Murray will only let her flirt with Sir Ashby, lest his mother come to believe that Rosalie is a bad girl—even though Sir Ashby himself is a terrible man. With alarm, Agnes asks whether Mrs. Murray knows this about Sir Ashby and still wants Rosalie to marry him. Rosalie says her mother does: in fact, Mrs. Murray has heard more critical gossip about Sir Ashby than she'll tell Rosalie. Rosalie doesn't mind, because "reformed rakes make the best husbands," but she wishes Sir Ashby were handsomer.

Rosalie too wants to exercise her energy and skill—but given the limited roles available to Victorian women, Rosalie channels all this energy, skill, and ambition into flirtation. A marriage to Sir Thomas Ashby, though a "victory" according to Rosalie's mother, would also constitute the end of Rosalie's "career" and ability to exercise her skills. Meanwhile, Mrs. Murray's desire that Rosalie marry Sir Ashby despite having heard terrible rumors about him shows how status-consciousness has warped her value system: she would rather her daughter have a rich husband (even if he's a "rake," or a wealthy but immoral man) than a good one.



When Agnes suggests that Mr. Hatfield would perhaps be a preferable match, Rosalie says he would—except that he doesn't have Ashby Park, which she wants. Agnes asks Rosalie to consider how she may wound Mr. Hatfield if she encourages him when she has no intention of marrying him. Rosalie says that she wants the entertainment—but eventually she'll "punish him" for daring to think that she could really like him. Despite Rosalie's claims, Agnes thinks the girl must be a little fond of Mr. Hatfield—for now that Agnes accompanies Rosalie on her walks beyond the property, she can see that Rosalie is angling to walk near the road and look for horsemen.

Four days after Rosalie's last meeting with Mr. Hatfield, she and Agnes are walking in the field when Rosalie abruptly announces that she has forgotten to give the cottager dying of consumption some money. She tosses Agnes her purse and hurriedly tells her to go to his house. As Agnes is leaving, she looks back and sees Mr. Hatfield—but she decides not to intervene, as the cottager could use the money, and Mr. Hatfield might "save [Rosalie] from a worse fate."

Agnes gives the consumptive man some money and reads to him. On her way out, she meets Mr. Weston coming in. They have a brief conversation—which she cherishes—and she continues on. A beaming Rosalie rushes to meet her and announces that Mr. Hatfield has proposed and that she sternly rejected him. Telling Agnes the story, Rosalie explains that Mr. Hatfield turned pale and asked whether she would still reject him if he were rich. She claimed she would—knowing she was lying. Angrily, he told her not to mention his proposal to anyone—and implied that if she did, he'd tell certain women in the parish that she led him on, thus starting gossip about her character that would damage her marriage prospects. Rosalie, annoyed, promised him she wouldn't tell anyone.

Agnes, shocked, points out that Rosalie just broke her promise. When Rosalie says that telling Agnes doesn't count because Agnes won't repeat the story, Agnes says that Rosalie is going to tell Matilda—and then the story will be everywhere. Agnes gets Rosalie to agree not to tell her maid but encourages her to tell Mrs. Murray. Rosalie says that she's happy to, since it will prove to her mother that she was in no danger. She's also happy to have "conquered" Mr. Hatfield—and to have demonstrated the self-command to reject a handsome suitor. Agnes asks whether she's as happy to have lied to him about wealth having no effect on her or about not telling anyone. Rosalie, annoyed, asks what else she could do and walks off. Agnes remains shocked at Rosalie's cruel egotism.

For Rosalie, love and marriage are status games. She plans to marry a man who can offer her an estate like Ashby Park, and she finds entertainment in "punish[ing]" men who aspire to marry her even though she believes they are lower status than she deserves. Agnes, who does not think of love as a status game, cannot understand this behavior and so assumes that Rosalie must really like Mr. Hatfield deep down.



Unlike Mrs. Murray, Agnes believes that love is a better foundation for marriage than wealth—likely due to the education Agnes received from her own parents, a poor but loving couple. The "worse fate" from which Agnes would like to save Rosalie is marriage to the immoral Sir Thomas Ashby. As such, Agnes disobeys Mrs. Murray to encourage a love match between Mr. Hatfield and Rosalie.



Rosalie's glee at having received and rejected a proposal from Mr. Hatfield underscores that she sees romance as a status game: because Mr. Hatfield loves her but she doesn't love him, she has "won" the game, proving herself higher-status than her suitor and licensing her to treat him cruelly. Mr. Hatfield's immediate response to romantic disappointment is to threaten Rosalie, which fits with the novel's earlier characterization of him as egotistical, cruel, and insincere in his religious practice.



Agnes has an (implicitly religious) moral commitment to honesty. Her pointed questions to Rosalie about Rosalie's lies are intended to educate Rosalie in appropriate moral values. Rosalie's annoyed dismissal of the questions shows Agnes's inability to educate Rosalie in values given Agnes's low status in Rosalie's household—Rosalie is not bound to listen to Agnes. Meanwhile, Agnes's genuine shock at Rosalie's egotistical pleasure at "conquer[ing]" Mr. Hatfield shows the two characters' different attitudes toward love.



CHAPTER 15: THE WALK

The next day, Rosalie is annoyed that Mr. Hatfield proposed so quickly. She's bored now without parties to attend or Mr. Hatfield to flirt with. On Sunday, she's likewise annoyed that Mr. Hatfield preaches rather than feigning illness—and that when he does preach, he doesn't look at her, though she claims that his strict failure to glance at her means he must have been thinking of her constantly.

One morning, Rosalie demands that Agnes walk with her into the village to shop. Agnes suspects Rosalie is hoping to run into Mr. Hatfield or some other admirer. After shopping, Rosalie runs into two young ladies she knows, and the three walk together. Agnes walks behind because she knows the girls will ignore her if she walks with them, which she finds annoying.

Mr. Weston approaches Agnes, notes she's walking alone again, and asks what sort of people the girls ahead are. Agnes admits she doesn't know, as they never talk to her. When Mr. Weston suggests that perhaps things like this are why Agnes says she couldn't live without a home, Agnes says it's more that she can't live without friends—and her family are her only friends. Mr. Weston asks whether she couldn't make more friends, and Agnes says that her governess job makes that hard. Mr. Weston asks whether Rosalie and Matilda aren't her friends, and Agnes says no—they have other friends they prefer.

Mr. Weston asks whether Agnes entertains herself by reading. She says she does, and for about half an hour they talk, Mr. Weston asking Agnes about her habits, thoughts, and questions. His interest makes Agnes's heart beat more noticeably. Yet after Rosalie's friends turn off toward their own home and Mr. Weston is about to say goodbye to Agnes, Rosalie turns around, sees him, and approaches, engaging him in bright conversation. After he finally does leave, Rosalie laughs and exults that she has "shot him through the heart." Agnes, horrified, silently prays for Mr. Weston's sake that Rosalie is incorrect—as well as feeling that her own hopes may be ruined.

Due to the limited social roles available to middle-class Victorian women, the goal of Rosalie's education is marriage. Without men to flirt with, Rosalie can't locate an outlet for her energy or intelligence. The social limitations on Rosalie lead her to destructive behavior, namely trying to break Mr. Hatfield's heart and becoming annoyed when he doesn't betray adequate symptoms of heartbreak.



Rosalie's restlessness when she lacks admirers shows how the Victorian emphasis on marriage as the end goal of middle-class young women's lives stunts their intellects and ambitions. The way that Rosalie and her friends conspicuously ignore Agnes, meanwhile, highlights their classist cruelty toward lower-status members of the Murray household.



The questions that Mr. Weston asks about Rosalie and her friends, as well as about Agnes's relationship to her home, make clear that he sees the classist cruelty and social isolation that the Murrays inflict on Agnes. His desire to talk to Agnes in turn makes clear that he does not share the Murrays' snobbery: he treats Agnes like a person worth talking to even though she is a female employee.



Agnes feels her heart beating when Mr. Weston engages her in attentive conversation, a physical cue that suggests her growing romantic attraction to him. Rosalie's claim that she has "shot [Mr. Weston] through the heart" emphasizes that she sees flirtation as a kind of violent status game: she is a hunter, Mr. Weston is her prey, and she establishes her superiority over him by figuratively "shooting" him. That Agnes prays Rosalie is wrong emphasizes the centrality of religion and shared religious values to Agnes's crush on Mr. Weston.



CHAPTER 16: THE SUBSTITUTION

The next Sunday, a rainy April day, Rosalie takes the carriage to church. Agnes accompanies her happily, for the service allows her to see and listen to Mr. Weston. The only shadow on her happiness is her fear that she's insulting God by thinking more about "the creature than the Creator," but she comforts herself with the thought that thinking on the goodness of God's creation constitutes worship.

When Agnes worries that she is thinking more about "the creature than the Creator," she means that she may be thinking more about Mr. Weston (a "creature") than about God ("the Creator"). She reassures herself with the thought that contemplating Mr. Weston's goodness—which ultimately derives from God—is a way of thinking about God's goodness. Agnes's thoughts in this passage showcase both her religiosity and her increasing passion for Mr. Weston.



After church, Rosalie and Agnes wait under the covered porch for the carriage. When Mr. Weston comes out, Rosalie asks him to visit one of the Murrays' sick cottagers. He agrees to visit at a particular time the next day. The carriage arrives, the footman walks Rosalie to it under an umbrella, and Mr. Weston offers to do the same for Agnes. After he hands Agnes into the carriage, Rosalie scowls and tells Agnes the footman would have come back for her. Agnes is a bit glad Rosalie is annoyed—hoping Rosalie has reason to think Mr. Weston prefers Agnes.

Rosalie is annoyed that Mr. Weston (who, notably, she does not want to marry) shows attentive politeness to Agnes, who actually admires Mr. Weston and might like to marry him. Rosalie's desire to "conquer" Mr. Weston, despite how much more Mr. Weston matters to Agnes both personally and socially, shows her fundamental thoughtlessness and egotism.



Rosalie tells Agnes that Sir Ashby will likely propose to her at a ball next Tuesday—and so, before then, she means to conquer Mr. Weston. Agnes silently wishes that Mr. Weston could hear Rosalie's talk. The next day, Rosalie comes into the schoolroom and demands Matilda go on a walk with her; when Matilda suggests that Agnes go instead, Rosalie demands her sister come, not Agnes. Later, at dinner, Agnes hears from them how they ran into Mr. Weston on his visit to the Murrays' cottager.

By implication, Rosalie doesn't want Agnes to walk with her because she plans to run into Mr. Weston and sees Agnes as a potential rival for Mr. Weston's affections. Again, Rosalie's desire to "conquer" Mr. Weston, a man she does not intend to marry, shows how limited roles for Victorian women and Rosalie's mother's focus on Rosalie's attractiveness have channeled Rosalie's energy and ambition into destructive behaviors.



CHAPTER 17: CONFESSIONS

Agnes admits to the reader that she has started spending up to two minutes in the mirror on her appearance, which dissatisfies her with its plainness. In childhood she was taught that one's interior matters more than one's exterior—but her experience suggests that people love beauty and judge women based on their looks. Morally good but not good-looking women are often ignored, while pretty women get away with bad behavior. Thus, unbeautiful people may feel they have a great capacity to love that never gets exercised.

In Victorian society, middle-class women are economically dependent on men and largely achieve economic security through marriage. When men choose wives based on women's looks, women are economically incentivized to be as attractive as possible—even as well-meaning educators tell them that their minds and morals matter more than beauty. Agnes, a morally good but not beautiful girl, finds the disjunction between what people claim to value and what they actually value frustrating.



On Tuesday, Rosalie and Mrs. Murray go to the Ashby Ball. The next morning, Rosalie tells Agnes that she has accepted a proposal from Sir Thomas Ashby and expresses glee at “becoming mistress of Ashby Park”—yet she also seems fearful of the marriage and wants to delay it. Agnes, who believes the marriage a bad idea and judges Mrs. Murray for pushing it, talks to Rosalie about her hesitation—and learns that Rosalie primarily wants to delay the wedding so that she can continue conquering hearts. Rosalie makes Agnes promise not to tell anyone she’s engaged. Agnes, disgusted, decides that Rosalie deserves Sir Ashby and that their wedding can’t come too soon.

Mrs. Murray has raised Rosalie to consider the conquest of a rich, high-ranking husband her primary goal in life. According to this worldview, Rosalie has completed her main task in life by accepting a proposal from Sir Thomas Ashby and “becoming mistress of Ashby Park.” Yet this victory means that Rosalie’s education in attractiveness and skills in flirtation are now obsolete. It may be this feeling of obsolescence, of her life being “over,” that leads Rosalie to want to delay her marriage. Agnes, who considers this view of love and marriage perverse, is in consequence disgusted with Rosalie’s fears.



The wedding is scheduled for six weeks later, in June. Sir Ashby travels to London to deal with business, which helps keep the engagement quiet. Meanwhile, one Mr. Green keeps writing Rosalie love letters, Harry Meltham keeps visiting, and Rosalie tries to ensnare Mr. Weston. Rosalie begins visiting the poor cottagers far more often, thus frequently running into Mr. Weston. She also insists that Agnes take the carriage to and from church rather than walking with her and Matilda—and, whenever possible, she prevents Agnes from attending church at all. Finally, she keeps Agnes so busy that Agnes has no time to visit Nancy Brown or other cottagers.

Rosalie abuses her power over Agnes, as her family’s employee, to keep Agnes away from Mr. Weston and pursue her own egotistical goal of “conquering” him—even though Rosalie does not love Mr. Weston and Agnes does. With this casual cruelty, Rosalie reveals her own egotism and lack of consideration for anyone of lower social status.



After Rosalie and Matilda run into Mr. Weston one morning, Matilda tells Agnes—despite Rosalie’s attempts to shush her—that Mr. Weston asked after her health, given that he sees her out so rarely. Agnes asks whether Nancy Brown ever asks after her. When Matilda says they told Nancy that Agnes preferred to read and draw at home, Agnes says that it would have been more accurate to say that the Murrays keep her too busy to go out. Rosalie snaps that Agnes has plenty of free time. Agnes doesn’t bother to answer. She tries hard not to display her indignation about or interest in the girls’ accounts of Mr. Weston, comforting herself that Rosalie will marry soon.

As a dependent employee in the Murray household, Agnes has very little power. Yet she still insists on telling the Murray girls the truth: they have been keeping her from leaving the household. This insistence on the truth is an indirect lesson to Rosalie, showing her that Agnes is aware of and hurt by Rosalie’s behavior. Rosalie’s irritated reaction suggests that she has enough of a conscience to be nettled by reminders of her bad behavior—or enough of an ego to be irritated by reminders that she is treating lowly Agnes as a romantic rival.



Unfortunately, Mr. Weston is likely to move away soon, as he and Mr. Hatfield have differing approaches and don’t get along. Agnes comforts herself with religion and with the thought that she at least appreciates Mr. Weston’s virtues in a way that Rosalie cannot. Unable to share her tormented feelings with anyone, Agnes ends up writing poetry about her loss of hope and her continued appreciation for her love (of, it is implied, Mr. Weston). Two other incidents hurt her as well: the Murrays give her terrier **Snap** away to the village rat-catcher, who treats his dogs badly; and she gets a letter from home that Richard Grey’s health is worsening.

The irreconcilable conflict between Mr. Weston and Mr. Hatfield reminds readers of Mr. Weston’s religious sincerity in contrast with Mr. Hatfield’s hypocrisy. When Agnes, tormented by love, takes refuge in religion, it suggests that sincere religiosity can be a comfort in hard times. Meanwhile, when the Murrays give away Agnes’s beloved terrier Snap to an abusive owner, their casual cruelty to the poor dog symbolizes their simultaneous cruelty to Agnes, as their dependent employee.



CHAPTER 18: MIRTH AND MOURNING

On June 1, Rosalie marries Sir Ashby. After the ceremony, she says goodbye to Agnes in the school room, promises not to forget Agnes, and asks why Agnes doesn't congratulate her. Agnes says she can't congratulate Rosalie until she's sure this life change is genuinely good for her but wishes her joy and "blessings." Rosalie, tearing up, hugs Agnes hard and rushes away. Agnes inwardly forgives Rosalie. She thinks Rosalie isn't fully aware of how much she's hurt Agnes and others, and she hopes God forgives her too.

That evening, Agnes visits Nancy Brown, apologizes for the hiatus in her visits, and asks about Mr. Weston. Nancy doesn't know whether the rumors about him leaving are true either. That Sunday, Agnes scrutinizes Mr. Weston to see whether Rosalie's marriage has devastated him. Happily, she sees no evidence of that. She walks home from church with Matilda, who is lonely, bored, and sullen. Mrs. Murray, having married off Rosalie, has turned her sights on Matilda. She's forbidden Matilda from associating with grooms, hunting **dogs**, and the like, leading to numerous fights between Matilda, her mother, and Mr. Murray. Mr. Murray thinks Matilda would have made a good son, but he believes she's failing as a daughter.

Mrs. Murray blames Agnes for not gently inducing Matilda to enjoy ladylike behavior and follow all her mother's commands, blaming her for not having shaped Matilda's preferences. She accuses Agnes of a lack of hard work, devotion, and investment in how her students reflect on her personally. Once, she even suggests that a less merciful employer would already be looking to replace Agnes. Before Agnes can reply, Mrs. Murray bustles off.

Matilda, bored and cooped up, begins to visit poor cottagers with Agnes. One day, Matilda and Agnes run into Mr. Weston, who asks Matilda if she has heard from Rosalie. Matilda says yes—Rosalie has written from Paris and is very happy. She says the last word with meaningful, impertinent emphasis, but Mr. Weston just says he hopes Rosalie will stay happy.

It is genuinely unclear to what extent Rosalie knows that she has hurt Agnes by pursuing Mr. Weston. Yet Rosalie's tears and Agnes's religiously motivated forgiveness of Rosalie suggest that both women are aware of potential future unhappiness in Rosalie's marriage to Sir Thomas Ashby.



Mr. Weston's lack of devastation at Rosalie's marriage implies that he was never dazzled by her flirtation or her social status, unlike the religiously hypocritical, status-conscious Mr. Hatfield. Meanwhile, Mr. Murray's sense that Matilda is a bad daughter but would have been a good son shows how limited the social roles available to Victorian women are: Matilda's virtues and interests can find no socially acceptable outlet because they are considered masculine, not feminine.



Mrs. Murray blames Agnes for the habits that Matilda learned from Mr. Murray before Agnes arrived—while also refusing to let Agnes speak sternly to Matilda to correct these behaviors. Needless to say, Mrs. Murray's desire to give Agnes no power over Matilda but all the responsibility for Matilda's behavior makes Agnes's job impossible.



When Mr. Weston says he hopes Rosalie will stay happy, it implies that he is aware of Sir Ashby's bad reputation and is worried that Rosalie's having married for money and status will lead to her ultimate unhappiness.



When Matilda runs off after her **dog**, Agnes asks Mr. Weston whether he thinks Rosalie will be happy, and Mr. Weston says that he doesn't know: while Rosalie's worst problem is "thoughtlessness," he has heard bad things about Sir Ashby. He asks Agnes whether Mrs. Murray wanted the marriage. Agnes says the lady did, and she believes Rosalie likely did too since she made fun of Agnes's attempts to persuade her not to go through with it. Mr. Weston says that at least Agnes can comfort herself that she tried—but he doesn't know how Mrs. Murray can live with herself. Agnes says that it's strange, but some people believe that marrying their children off to high-born, rich spouses is the most important thing.

Matilda returns. She and Agnes continue on their errand, and Mr. Weston on his. But on the way back, they run into him again, and he picks Agnes some **bluebells**, having remembered that they're one of her favorite flowers. Agnes goes home happy and hopeful—but the next morning she receives a letter from her mother that Richard is very ill. Mrs. Murray—reluctantly, claiming there's no need to rush, and praising her own "consideration"—allows Agnes to leave for her upcoming vacation a little early. When Agnes arrives home late that night, her mother and Mary, looking very pale, meet her and tell her that her father has died.

Agnes and Mr. Weston both disapprove of Sir Thomas Ashby's immoral reputation and of Mrs. Murray's desire to marry off Rosalie to him anyway due to his wealth and high rank. This shared disapproval implies their shared religious and social values: morality is more important than money or status—and parents should teach their children as much.



Mr. Weston remembers Agnes's favorite flowers and picks them for her without being asked. His quiet attentiveness to her desires and preferences hints that he may return her affections. His use of bluebells to communicate his affections to her, meanwhile, strengthens the symbolic association the novel has made between flowers and love. When Mrs. Murray praises her own "consideration" in letting Agnes take vacation a few days early to visit her extremely sick father, meanwhile, it shows how callous and inconsiderate employers can be of their dependent employees' needs.



CHAPTER 19: THE LETTER

After Richard Grey's funeral, Agnes, Mary, and their mother sit around the table and discuss their future. Though Mary asks their mother to come live with her and her new husband, their mother resolves to work while she can. She suggests that she and Agnes start a small school for boarders and day students. Agnes agrees to use her savings to rent a suitable house: she will give notice upon returning to Horton Lodge.

A letter arrives for Agnes's mother. It's from her father. She reads it, throws it down on the table, and tells Agnes and Mary that their grandfather has offered to support her and write Agnes and Mary into his will if she'll acknowledge that she was wrong to have married Richard Grey in the first place and regrets it. She plans to write back that she in no way regrets her 30 years of marriage or the two daughters that resulted from it—but since her father is offering Agnes and Mary an inheritance, she asks what they think. They strongly support her decision. After their grandfather's death, they eventually hear that he left all his money to their cousins.

Agnes's mother's dilemma after her husband's death underscores the limited "respectable" choices available to middle-class Victorian women: once her husband dies, she can either become a dependent on other family members or work in education—and that's about all.



Agnes has demonstrated that she values love and morality over money and status throughout the novel—particularly in her opposition to the marriage between Rosalie and rich, high-ranking, but immoral Sir Ashby. This scene emphasizes that Agnes learned these values from her parents and particularly her mother, who refuses to lie about regretting her loving marriage even in order to obtain economic security.



CHAPTER 20: THE FAREWELL

Agnes's mother rents a house in a fashionable town and finds some initial students. Though some people might pity the poor for having to work through their grief, Agnes thinks work comforts her mother. She herself is very sad to leave her childhood home forever for her last six weeks at Horton Lodge. Two weeks after her return, while she is walking back from visiting Nancy Brown, Mr. Weston runs into her and asks sympathetically how her mother is doing. After Agnes explains their plans, he asks when she's leaving and whether she's happy to go. When Agnes says she's happy in some ways, Mr. Weston asks how leaving could make her sad—and Agnes, embarrassed, answers evasively.

Mr. Weston asks whether Agnes will miss Matilda. Agnes says she probably will—after all, she misses Rosalie, and Matilda is in some respects better because she's honest. When Mr. Weston asks whether Rosalie wasn't honest, Agnes hedges and says she's "a little artful." Mr. Weston says that that description makes sense of some behavior from Rosalie, whom he already knew was vain, that confused him before.

Mr. Weston walks out of his way to accompany Agnes and talk with her. After they part, Agnes thinks to herself that she could be happy anywhere if he were her true friend. Yet for the next month, she rarely sees him. On her final Sunday in the village, Agnes has to hold back tears in church, thinking that the service is the last time she'll hear Mr. Weston's voice. But as she's leaving the church, he stops her to say goodbye to her. He says they could meet again and asks whether it matters to her if they do. Agnes says it does: she would be "very glad" to meet him again. They part.

CHAPTER 21: THE SCHOOL

Agnes leaves Horton Lodge and goes to work at her mother's school, where they have three boarding students and six day students but plan to take on more. Agnes finds working in her own school much better to working as a family's employee as a governess, but she still thinks of Mr. Weston, hoping that his mention of them meeting again means he'll write or visit. When she receives no letter from him, her hope and common sense do battle. Her hope thinks he still meant something by his parting words, while her common sense claims he didn't. Eventually, as she still hears nothing from Mr. Weston, her common sense wins out—though she cherishes his memory, she no longer expects him to appear.

Agnes believes that work comforts her grieving mother, a belief suggesting that people benefit from and want to exercise their energies and talents. This belief suggests, for instance, that it is no wonder that Rosalie ends up a shameless flirt when her society has taught her to channel her intelligence and ambition only into attracting men. Meanwhile, Mr. Weston's question to Agnes hints that he is seeking indirect confirmation that she has feelings for him—confirmation Agnes is too shy to provide.



In the Victorian context, the word "artful" can have negative connotations of artificiality and manipulativeness. When Mr. Weston finds the description of Rosalie as "artful" revealing, it implies that he has just realized Rosalie was flirting with him not because she liked him but because she wanted to manipulate him.



Agnes's belief that she could be happy so long as Mr. Weston is her friend emphasizes the novel's implicit argument that a happy life is based on love and friendship rather than wealth or status. Shy Agnes's admission that she would be "very glad" to see Mr. Weston again is as close as she can bring herself to a confession of love at this point.



Agnes does not elaborate on her preference for working in her own school over working as a governess. Yet given how the Bloomfields and the Murrays abused their power over Agnes, readers can assume that self-employment as a teacher perhaps offers Agnes the ability to discipline her students, which she routinely couldn't as a governess. Meanwhile, Agnes's longing for Mr. Weston shows that she still feels love is important to her happiness.



One morning during the Easter holidays, Agnes's mother tells her that she looks terrible and is probably working too hard. Agnes tries to reassure her mother, but she's surprised at the commentary. She knows that, having lost hope she'll see Mr. Weston again or ever get to love someone, she has become deeply depressed—but now she chides herself for not resigning herself to the work and trials God has set before her. She stops letting herself think of Mr. Weston so often, and as summer approaches, she can feel herself getting stronger and healthier.

In June, Agnes receives a letter from Rosalie, who is now living at Ashby Park. In the letter, Rosalie apologizes for not keeping up a correspondence with Agnes, begs Agnes to come visit her at Ashby Park as soon as her school vacation starts, and mentions as an aside that if Agnes likes children, Rosalie's baby daughter should be an added incentive—though Sir Ashby hasn't forgiven Rosalie for having a girl. She also mentions that, as far as Ashby Park goes, "the promise of anticipation exceeds the pleasure of possession." Agnes decides to go, concluding that Rosalie is probably deeply unhappy and that Agnes will help if she can. She also hopes that she might hear something about Mr. Weston.

Agnes believes that love is important to happiness and that she may have lost her one opportunity for love. Understandably, this belief makes her unhappy. Yet she is able to find solace in religion, highlighting that religion can be a source of strength and resilience for sincerely devout people.



When Rosalie mentions that Sir Thomas Ashby has not forgiven her for giving birth to a girl, it both indicates the low esteem in which Victorian society holds women and hints at unhappiness in Rosalie's marriage. Meanwhile, Rosalie's comment that "the promise of anticipation exceeds the pleasure of possession," she means that she thought she would enjoy being the mistress of an aristocratic estate more than she in fact does. Contrary to what her mother taught her, wealth and rank do not lead to happiness.



CHAPTER 22: THE VISIT

Arriving at Ashby Park, Agnes finds it beautiful but hardly thinks it worth the price Rosalie paid for it—though she mentions that she isn't inclined to criticize Rosalie anymore. Rosalie tries so hard to make Agnes, whom she assumes will be overawed by the grand surroundings, comfortable that Agnes is a little annoyed and discomfited. Agnes notices that Rosalie herself has lost weight and looks dispirited; she wants to ask how Rosalie is but feels unable to do so.

Rosalie shows Agnes her guest bedroom and a sitting room where she can take her meals if she doesn't want to eat with Sir Ashby and his mother. Agnes, to Rosalie's evident relief, says she would prefer to take her meals alone. Then Rosalie brings Agnes to the done-up drawing room—Agnes looks impressed to please her—and shows her various mementoes of her European honeymoon. When Agnes asks after Rosalie's family and their village acquaintances, Rosalie mentions that jealous Sir Ashby took her away from London because Harry Meltham was following her around there. Agnes looks alarmed, and Rosalie claims that she can't help having admirers.

Rosalie's obvious misery underscores another one of the main "lessons" of Agnes's story: money and rank matter less than morality and love.



Rosalie is relieved that Agnes doesn't want to eat with Sir Thomas Ashby and his mother—suggesting either that Rosalie would be embarrassed to socialize with her low-ranking former governess in front of her high-ranking in-laws or that her high-ranking in-laws would likely be rude to Agnes. This underscores the callousness and cruelty in the Victorian social hierarchy. Meanwhile, the reappearance of Harry Meltham suggests that Rosalie—who has only ever been educated in how to flirt—has continued trying to "conquer" men after her marriage even though such behavior is not socially condoned for a married woman.



Agnes works her way around to asking after Mr. Weston. Rosalie says she doesn't know much, only that he left the Horton village church about a month before due to constant conflict with Mr. Hatfield. Then she says she must dress for dinner—and curses her judgmental mother-in-law right in front of the footman. When Agnes points out that the footman must have heard her, Rosalie claims that footmen are just “automatons.”

Yet again, the conflict between Mr. Weston and Mr. Hatfield reminds readers of the former's sincere religiosity in contrast with the latter's hypocrisy. Rosalie's claim that the footmen are “automatons”—i.e. robots—underscores how higher-ranking characters tend to treat lower-ranking characters as less than fully human.



Agnes takes her meal alone. Near bedtime, Rosalie comes to see her, apologizes for leaving her alone so long, and blames her mother-in-law—whom, she claims, criticizes Rosalie for leaving the drawing room after dinner if Sir Ashby comes in, even though he's frequently drunk. Agnes suggests that Rosalie could try to use her intelligence and accomplishments to improve Sir Ashby's mind and habits, but Rosalie says that it is a husband's job to please his wife, not the other way around. Agnes tells Rosalie that she's going to bed.

Agnes conceives of wives as having talents and duties that they can use to help and improve their husbands. By contrast, Rosalie has been thoroughly educated on how to catch a husband but not on how to occupy herself or behave toward her husband once she is married. As such, she finds herself angry and helpless in the face of her boorish husband's bad behavior.



CHAPTER 23: THE PARK

The next morning, Agnes comes down for breakfast and is left waiting for ages until Rosalie appears. Rosalie insists on showing her Ashby Park's gardens. As the women walk, a man with an unpleasant face rides by on horseback. Rosalie whispers that she loathes him. When Agnes asks who he is, Rosalie explains that he's her husband, Sir Thomas Ashby. Agnes points out that Rosalie knew what Sir Ashby was like when she married him, but Rosalie claims that she didn't know the half of it—and she wishes she had listened to Agnes's warnings. He's controlling and wishes to keep her in the countryside so she can't flirt with Harry Meltham or spend money, though he himself gambles, has affairs, and drinks too much.

Mrs. Murray taught her daughter to believe that “reformed rakes make the best husbands,” but it seems that Sir Thomas Ashby is not reformed: he continues to binge drink, gamble, and conduct affairs after marrying Rosalie. Implicitly, Mrs. Murray hid the worst of Sir Thomas Ashby's behavior from Rosalie before the wedding because she wanted Rosalie to marry the richest, highest-ranking man possible—a deception that shows how Mrs. Murray's poor education of Rosalie and misplaced values have condemned her daughter to an unhappy marriage. Moreover, having been educated only to flirt, Rosalie lacks the internal resources of someone like Agnes to make the best of an unhappy situation: to console herself, she only knows how to flirt and buy things.



Rosalie bursts into tears. Agnes pities Rosalie both for having married Sir Ashby and for misunderstanding what a good life consists of. She advises Rosalie to work improvements on her husband—and, if she can't, to stand fast to her own morals, find comfort in religion, and focus on her child. Rosalie says she can't focus all her life on her daughter. She won't be able to find any enjoyment in watching the girl grow up to become more beautiful than Rosalie and have fun that Rosalie can't anymore. As for Agnes's moral teachings, Rosalie might follow them if she were middle-aged, but while she's young, she wants pleasure.

Agnes's parents educated her to find meaning and self-respect in moral behavior, religious devotion, and care for others. As such, Agnes believes that Rosalie can improve her life through religion and care for her baby daughter. Rosalie, who never received a moral education like Agnes's, cannot accept the religious stoicism and other-focused life that Agnes advises.



Agnes firmly repeats her advice that Rosalie pursue goodness, the sooner the better. She also suggests that Rosalie try to make a friend and ally of her mother-in-law. Yet she suspects that Rosalie won't take her advice, which makes the visit to Ashby Park even more unpleasant. Agnes leaves a few days later, gently rejecting Rosalie's requests that she stay longer—and thinking that if Rosalie had what she wanted, she wouldn't want Agnes's company.

Agnes's visit to Ashby Park constitutes a final failure in her attempt to educate Rosalie: though Agnes has attempted to teach Rosalie moral behavior and religious devotion through instruction and example, Rosalie ultimately learned values from her superficial, materialistic mother that Agnes was not able to counteract. As such, Agnes is unable to help Rosalie in her unwise, unhappy marriage.



CHAPTER 24: THE SANDS

Agnes and her mother's school is in a coastal town, and Agnes loves walking along the seaside. Three days after returning from Ashby Park, Agnes gets up very early and goes for a walk by the sea. After strolling for almost an hour, she sees some grooms and, in the distance, a gentleman walking a **dog**. Agnes walks on. A little later, the dog comes running up to her—and Agnes sees that it's her old terrier Snap! Agnes picks Snap up, kisses him, and looks for his new owner, only to see Mr. Weston.

Snap's appearance with Mr. Weston hints that Mr. Weston saved Snap from the abusive rat-catcher—a gesture that emphasizes both Mr. Weston's kindness toward helpless creatures and his unspoken love for Agnes, out of whose care the Murrays cruelly sold Snap.



Mr. Weston greets Agnes, who to her own surprise maintains her composure. He accompanies her as she walks back toward town and mentions that he was never able to figure out where she lived. Agnes—wondering whether he had tried to find out where she lived—gives her address. Mr. Weston asks after the school. When Agnes says that it's doing very well and adding students thanks to her mother's excellent work, Mr. Weston asks to be introduced to her and to have the pleasure of calling upon her and Agnes. Agnes, flustered, agrees.

Agnes's mother is apparently flourishing as a teacher, showing that determined and intelligent women make something of their lives in Victorian society despite the extreme limitations placed on them. When Mr. Weston implies that he tried to figure out where Agnes lived, meanwhile, he is indirectly suggesting that he has been looking from her since she left Horton Village.



Agnes mentions that she had heard Mr. Weston left Horton. Mr. Weston says that he is working in a village parish two miles from the town. When Agnes congratulates him on his new job, Mr. Weston says he has reforms he wants to make—but that all his life really needs now is “a companion.” Agnes, blushing painfully, tells him he might find any number of willing potential companions in the village or the nearby town. Mr. Weston replies that he's not so arrogant as to suppose so—but that he himself also has particular criteria for a companion, so perhaps these potential ladies wouldn't suit him.

When Mr. Weston says that all his life needs is “a companion,” he implies that a loving marriage is an essential component for a full and happy life. This implication suggests an alignment between his values and Agnes's, as Agnes has learned from her poor but loving parents' marriage that affectionate partnership matters more than money or status to a good life.



A lull falls in Agnes and Mr. Weston's conversation as they cross a crowded section of the seaside leading into town. Then Mr. Weston suggests that Agnes must not come to the beach often, because he walks there frequently but hasn't seen her. He also mentions that he's looked for her school but couldn't find it. Agnes asks when he'll come to call on her mother, and he says he'll do so the next day. Mr. Weston calls **Snap** away—saying that he likes Snap too much to give him back—and he and Agnes part. Agnes goes home praying that her hopes will be fulfilled this time.

As kindness toward animals correlates with goodness throughout the novel, Mr. Weston's affection for Snap yet again highlights his admirability and suitability for Agnes as a husband. His request to call on Agnes's family, meanwhile, hints that he intends to court Agnes respectfully. Agnes's prayers at the end of the passage remind readers that shared religious values have formed the basis of her and Mr. Weston's mutual affection.



CHAPTER 25: CONCLUSION

Over breakfast, Agnes's mother notices how flustered Agnes looks. Agnes collects herself and tells her mother that she ran into Mr. Weston, the former curate of Horton, on the seashore. She and Mr. Weston had a brief conversation, and Mr. Weston asked whether he could call on Agnes's mother. Agnes asks whether that's all right. Her mother says yes and asks what Mr. Weston is like. Agnes describes him as "very respectable." Mr. Weston visits the next day. He and Agnes's mother get on very well. After he leaves, Agnes's mother asks why Agnes didn't talk more. Agnes claims that it was because Mr. Weston was visiting her mother, not her.

When Agnes describes Mr. Weston as "very respectable," it's a funny moment in the novel: women don't usually describe the objects of their romantic passion as "respectable." Yet this unexpected description highlights that Agnes loves Mr. Weston because she respects his religious sincerity and his kindness toward animals and the poor. Thus the description suggests how well suited Agnes and Mr. Weston are for each other.



Mr. Weston begins visiting Agnes and her mother several times a week and becomes their close family friend. One evening, he asks Agnes to walk with him. As they walk along the coast, Mr. Weston first looks very serious and then very happy. He tells Agnes that, having met all the ladies in his parish, he only wants Agnes as his life companion—and asks her for her response. Agnes asks whether he's serious, and he asks in return whether he'd joke about something like that. Then Agnes says she needs her mother's permission. Mr. Weston says he has already received her mother's permission and asks whether Agnes has any more objections. Agnes says no. Mr. Weston asks whether that means she loves him—and she says she does.

Agnes only admits that she loves Mr. Weston after she knows her mother has given permission for their marriage and after Mr. Weston has assured her he isn't joking in his proposal. Her hesitancy reveals her shyness and lack of self-esteem—perhaps a result of her callous treatment by the Bloomfields and Murrays—as well as her devotion to her mother.



A few weeks after, Agnes's mother finds another teacher's assistant, and Agnes marries Mr. Weston. She has yet to regret her decision. Though she and Mr. Weston have encountered troubles, they support each other through them. Their main worry is separation by death—but religious hope for the afterlife will support them through that trial too. They have a son and two daughters, whom Agnes homeschools, and they live adequately on Mr. Weston's modest income by being frugal and not trying to keep up with any rich neighbors. Thus, Agnes's story ends.

Agnes and Mr. Weston's happy marriage despite their small income emphasizes one of the novel's major lessons: love matters more than money in marriage. Agnes's decision to homeschool her children emphasizes another major lesson: parents have enormous power when it comes to teaching their children not only academic subjects but also values, and they need to understand that that power comes with responsibility.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Prendergast, Finola. "Agnes Grey." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 12 Dec 2023. Web. 12 Dec 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Prendergast, Finola. "Agnes Grey." LitCharts LLC, December 12, 2023. Retrieved December 12, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/agnes-grey>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Agnes Grey* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Brontë, Anne. *Agnes Grey*. Wordsworth Editions. 1998.

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Brontë, Anne. *Agnes Grey*. Ware: Wordsworth Editions. 1998.